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*Quantifying Public Sentiment Toward Climate Action (SDG 13) Through Reddit Discourse*

*[In]*

A report submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Science

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## ABSTRACT

Climate change represents a defining challenge of our time, with Sustainable Development Goal 13 (Climate Action) calling for an urgent global response. However, a critical gap persists in understanding genuine public engagement and sentiment toward the specific targets of SDG 13, as traditional assessment methods are often limited in scale and authenticity. This research addresses this gap by conducting a large-scale computational analysis of public sentiment toward climate action through the lens of Reddit discourse.

Utilizing a novel hybrid sentiment analysis framework that integrates the social media optimization of VADER with the domain-specificity of ClimateBERT, this study analyzed 46,630 English-language Reddit comments from 10 climate-relevant communities between January 2019 and July 2024. The methodology enabled a multi-dimensional investigation of sentiment across SDG 13 subtopics, temporal events, community contexts, and geographical mentions.

The findings reveal a complex landscape of "cautious optimism." A significant technology-policy paradox was identified: strong public optimism surrounds technological solutions like renewable energy (mean sentiment: +0.112), contrasting sharply with skepticism toward climate policy (+0.035). The study also found that major events like the COP26 conference had a limited and transient impact on sustained public discourse. Furthermore, sentiment varied profoundly across different Reddit communities, from positive and solution-oriented (+0.29) to negative and contentious (-0.14), and revealed a significant sentiment divided in how Global North and Global South regions are discursively framed.

This research makes significant contributions by methodologically validating a hybrid framework for domain-specific sentiment analysis, theoretically advancing our understanding of framing and affective publics in digital spaces, and providing practical, evidence-based strategies for policymakers and communicators to enhance public engagement with climate action in line with SDG Target 13.3.

**Keywords:** Climate Action, SDG 13, Sentiment Analysis, Natural Language Processing, Reddit, Computational Social Science, Public Discourse, Climate Communication.

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# CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

## 1.1 Background and Context: The Climate Communication Imperative

Climate change represents one of the most critical challenges of the modern era, with extensive implications for global environmental, economic, and social systems(Rockström et al., 2014; Soergel et al., 2021). The international response has been coordinated through frameworks such as the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), within which SDG 13 (Climate Action) mandates "urgent action to combat climate change and its impacts" (Coenen et al., 2021). Despite this clear directive, an implementation gap persists, with current policies projected to result in significantly above-target warming, Cuts of ~42% by 2030 and ~57% by 2035 are needed for a 1.5 °C path; current pledges track ~2.6–3.1 °C (Olhoff et al., 2024). A specific challenge within this gap is Target 13.3, which focuses on improving education, awareness-raising, and capacity but lacks robust mechanisms for measuring genuine public engagement and sentiment (Pattberg & Bäckstrand, 2023)

Traditional methods for assessing public opinion, such as surveys and focus groups, provide valuable insights but are constrained by limitations, including participant bias, high costs, limited sample sizes, and a lack of scalability (Bayer & Ovodenko, 2019). A significant issue is social desirability bias, where respondents may not express their true feelings on contentious topics, such as climate policy (Sparkman et al., 2022). Furthermore, these methods cannot easily capture the organic, spontaneous nature of public discourse that unfolds in real-time digital environments. These constraints have necessitated the exploration of innovative methodologies utilising digital platforms and computational techniques (Kaushal et al., 2022)

## 1.2 The Emergence of Computational Social Science

The rise of Computational Social Science (CSS) has provided a paradigm shift in the study of public discourse, enabling the analysis of human behaviour at an unprecedented scale and depth (Xue et al., 2020) This field leverages large-scale digital data and applies computational techniques such as sentiment analysis, topic modelling, and social network analysis to understand complex social phenomena (Xue et al., 2020).

Social media platforms are particularly valuable data sources for CSS, offering access to real-time, large-scale naturalistic data on public attitudes and (Lazer et al., 2020). Among these platforms, Reddit is uniquely suited for analysing climate discourse. Its structure of topic-specific communities (subreddits) facilitates focused and in-depth discussion on niche subjects, a contrast to the decentralised nature of platforms like X (formerly Twitter) (Massanari, 2016a). The platform's support for extended conversations and its culture of relative anonymity can encourage more candid expression than identity-centric platforms like Facebook (Van Der Nagel & Frith, 2019). Reddit's comprehensive public archive also allows for longitudinal analysis,

tracking how discourse evolves in response to events such as international climate conferences or policy announcements (Baumgartner et al., 2020)

### 1.3 Advances in Natural Language Processing for Climate Discourse

Progress in Natural Language Processing (NLP) has been instrumental in enabling the computational analysis of climate-related text data (Ojadi & Odionu, 2025). Sentiment analysis, a key NLP technique, is used to identify and quantify subjective information and emotional tone within text data (Pang & Lee, 2008). Lexicon-based models like VADER (Valence Aware Dictionary and Sentiment Reasoner) are highly effective for social media text, as they are tuned to handle informal language, slang, and emoticons (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014)

However, climate discourse often involves technical terminology and nuanced context that generic models may misinterpret. This has led to the development of domain-specific language models like ClimateBERT, which is pre-trained on a large corpus of climate-related documents to achieve a superior understanding of domain-specific language (Webersinke et al., 2021). The combination of such specialised semantic models with other NLP techniques like topic modelling (e.g., Latent Dirichlet Allocation) allows for a more nuanced analysis that moves beyond treating "climate change" as a monolithic category, enabling researchers to distinguish sentiment and discussion patterns across different subtopics, such as renewable energy versus climate policy (Bucur et al., 2024).

### 1.4 Research Problem and Identified Gaps

Despite a growing body of research on general climate change discourse on social media (Yin et al., 2024) significant gaps remain in the literature concerning SDG 13-specific discourse.

First, there is a lack of focus on how public sentiment varies across different subtopics integral to SDG 13, such as mitigation, adaptation, and policy. Much of the existing research tends to treat climate change as a single entity, overlooking the nuanced public engagement with its various components (Bernstein & Hoffmann, 2019). Second, insufficient attention has been paid to how discourse and sentiment are shaped by the distinct norms and values of different online community contexts, such as science-focused versus policy-focused subreddits (Phadke, 2025). Third, from a methodological standpoint, there is a reliance on generic sentiment analysis tools, with a clear need for hybrid or domain-adapted approaches that can accurately capture the specifics of climate-related language (Webersinke et al., 2021). This study aims to address these gaps by applying an advanced computational methodology specifically to SDG 13-related discourse on Reddit.

### 1.5 Research Aim, Questions, and Objectives

The primary aim of this research is to conduct a comprehensive analysis of public sentiment toward SDG 13 on Reddit, identifying key patterns across different subtopics, temporal events, and community contexts.

This aim is addressed through the following research questions:

1. **RQ1:** How is sentiment distributed across different subtopics of SDG 13 (e.g., renewable energy, climate policy, climate justice)?
2. **RQ2:** How does the COP26 climate conference influence the volume and sentiment of climate action discourse?
3. **RQ3:** How does sentiment toward climate action vary across different Reddit communities with distinct norms and focus areas?
4. **RQ4:** How are different world regions discussed within climate action discourse, and how does sentiment vary across geographical mentions?

To answer these questions, the study has the following objectives:

1. To develop and validate a novel hybrid sentiment analysis framework that integrates the social media optimisation of VADER with the domain-specificity of ClimateBERT.
2. To construct a comprehensive dataset of English-language Reddit comments relevant to SDG 13 from January 2019 to July 2024.
3. To analyse the distribution and intensity of public sentiment across key subtopics of SDG 13.
4. To assess the longitudinal impact of the COP26 conference on discourse volume and sentiment.
5. To compare sentiment patterns across different types of Reddit communities (e.g., science-focused, policy-focused).

To map and compare sentiment in discussions that mention different world regions.

### 1.6 Research Significance and Thesis Structure

This study contributes significantly to the field. Methodologically, it develops and validates a hybrid framework for domain-adapted sentiment analysis, providing a model for future research on specialised discourses. Theoretically, it contributes to framing theory (Entman, 1993) and agenda-setting theory (Mccombs & Shaw, 1972) by examining how climate action is framed and gains prominence across different digital communities. Practically, the findings offer actionable insights for policymakers, educators, and communicators working to enhance public engagement in line with SDG Target 13.3.

This dissertation is structured into six chapters. Following this introduction, Chapter 2 presents a comprehensive literature review covering climate communication, social media research, and computational methods. Chapter 3 details the research methodology, including data collection, the hybrid sentiment analysis framework, and statistical analysis plan. Chapter 4 presents the empirical findings of the study. Chapter 5 discusses the implications of these findings, linking them back to the literature and research questions. Finally, Chapter 6 concludes the dissertation by

summarising the key contributions, acknowledging limitations, and suggesting directions for future research.

# CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

## 2.1 Introduction

Climate change is not only a scientific and policy challenge, but also a communication challenge that depends heavily on public meaning-making, public attention, and public emotions. In the past, climate change communication research focused mainly on traditional media and institutional messaging. However, the growth of social platforms has shifted climate discourse into spaces where non-experts actively interpret, contest, and reshape climate narratives in real time. Social media has therefore become a key site for observing how climate action-related issues are framed, how attention rises and falls around major climate events, and how people express emotional reactions to climate risks and policy debates.

This literature review connects three areas that support the dissertation's focus: (1) the SDG 13 context and the communication relevance of climate action, (2) theoretical foundations for studying public discourse online (framing, agenda-setting, and affective publics), and (3) computational approaches that allow large-scale analysis of climate conversations. The review also positions Reddit as a valuable platform for studying climate-related public discourse due to its community structure, discussion depth, and persistence of conversations. Finally, it highlights research gaps that justify this dissertation's design: combining SDG 13 thematic coding with sentiment measurement, temporal event comparison (COP26), and geo-referencing at scale using Reddit discussions.

## 2.2 The Sustainable Development Goal 13 Context

The United Nations 2030 Agenda frames climate change as an urgent global challenge requiring both mitigation and adaptation, which is formally reflected in **SDG 13: Climate Action** (*United Nations,* 2015). SDG 13 is not only about policy implementation but also about strengthening knowledge, public capacity, and institutional readiness, including improving awareness and action through education and communication. This matters because climate policy success depends on legitimacy, cooperation, and the social conditions that support behavioral change and acceptance of transition-related costs.

Climate action debates occur inside political and cultural conflicts: climate change is understood differently depending on values, identity, ideology, and perceived fairness. Climate communication research has repeatedly shown that the same scientific information can lead to different interpretations depending on how it is framed, how risks are perceived, and how solutions are evaluated. Risk perception is shaped by affective responses, personal experience with extreme weather, social norms, and worldviews, not only factual knowledge (Van Der Linden et al., 2015). This helps

explain why climate communication can become polarised, where the public debates are not just about evidence but about trust, identity, and what forms of change are seen as acceptable.

As climate action initiatives such as COP conferences, national net-zero pledges, and energy transitions become more visible, public discourse increasingly reflects both support and resistance. Online discussions can reveal how climate action is interpreted across topics like renewable energy, policy regulation, justice, and economic trade-offs. Because SDG 13 connects climate action to wider development and equity concerns, analyzing climate discourse through SDG 13-relevant themes is a useful way to interpret what the public focuses on and what types of arguments are most emotionally charged.

## 2.3 Theoretical Foundations for Digital Climate Discourse Analysis

### 2.3.1 Framing Theory and Climate Communication

Framing theory explains how communication highlights certain aspects of reality and makes them more salient, shaping how problems are defined, what causes are emphasized, and what solutions seem reasonable. Entman (1993) describes framing as selecting certain aspects of perceived reality to promote particular problem definitions, causal interpretations, moral evaluations, and treatment recommendations. This is especially relevant in climate debates because climate change is complex and often interpreted through simplified narratives that influence whether the issue feels urgent, solvable, or threatening.

Social movement scholarship also treats framing as a core process for mobilizing support and sustaining collective action. Benford & Snow (2000)explain that effective collective action frames often include diagnostic framing (what is wrong and who is responsible), prognostic framing (what should be done), and motivational framing (why people should act). Climate discourse often matches this structure: discussions attribute responsibility to governments, corporations, or consumers; propose solutions like renewable energy or regulation; and seek to motivate action through moral urgency or fear about future risks.

In climate communication research, framing is frequently used to analyze how climate change is positioned as a risk, an opportunity, a moral crisis, a scientific debate, or an economic burden. Work on science communication frames argues that climate narratives become persuasive when they connect with audiences' values and lived experiences (Nisbet, 2009). This is relevant to online discourse because ordinary users actively "frame" climate issues themselves rather than only receiving frames from journalists or institutions. In digital environments, frames emerge through interaction, repetition, and community norms, meaning framing becomes a participatory and contested process.

### 2.3.2 Agenda-Setting Theory in Digital Environments

Agenda-setting theory focuses on how attention is shaped: which issues become

prominent and which remain marginal. The classic agenda-setting argument is that media may not dictate what people think, but strongly influences what people think about by making certain issues more visible and frequent (Mccombs & Shaw, 1972). Climate change historically rises and falls in public attention depending on events, political conflict, and media coverage. This matters for SDG 13 because attention cycles can shape policy momentum, activism, and public support.

In digital settings, agenda-setting becomes more complex because attention is influenced by both professional media and user-driven sharing. Research on intermedia agenda-setting shows that online spaces can shape mainstream agendas and vice versa, including in fragmented environments where traditional outlets compete with partisan and emerging sources (Vargo et al., 2017). The implication is that climate discourse may be reactive to major events (such as COP conferences or disasters) and that online public attention can be measured through high-volume discussion streams.

For climate-focused research, comparing sentiment and discourse patterns before, during, and after high-profile climate events is a meaningful way to identify whether events intensify engagement, shift narratives, or trigger backlash. Online platforms enable fine-grained temporal analysis that would be difficult in surveys. This dissertation's event-based comparison around COP26 aligns with the agenda-setting logic that major events can re-structure attention, even if the direction of opinion is not uniform.

### 2.3.3 Affective Publics and Emotional Engagement

Beyond frames and attention, climate discourse is deeply emotional. Climate change generates fear, anxiety, anger, hope, and moral judgement, and these emotions influence engagement and polarisation. Papacharissi (2015) argues that networked publics are often organised through affective expression, where emotions circulate and help form collective meaning and identity. In digital spaces, emotions are visible in language, tone, and interaction patterns, which makes sentiment analysis relevant for understanding climate discourse.

Climate communication research also suggests that emotional strategies matter: purely fear-based messaging can be counterproductive if it reduces efficacy or creates disengagement (O'neill & Nicholson-Cole, 2009). Emotions do not operate separately from frames; instead, the emotional tone of a frame can influence how credible and motivating it feels. This is important for SDG 13 discussions where users debate responsibility, justice, sacrifice, and future risk. Therefore, analysing sentiment alongside thematic categories allows a more complete view of how climate action topics are experienced and contested.

## 2.4 The Evolution of Climate Change Communication and Public Engagement

Climate change communication has expanded from scientific reporting into broader public and political debate. Research shows that climate communication is shaped by

media systems, political contexts, and public engagement dynamics, influencing how climate risks and solutions are interpreted (Moser; Sch, 2012). As communication shifts toward digital platforms, climate discourse increasingly reflects public participation, contestation, and polarisation rather than purely scientific reporting.

Online communication also changes who participates. Users do not simply consume messages; they respond, reinterpret, and circulate them. This participatory environment helps explain why climate narratives are not stable: discussions can shift quickly from scientific evidence to policy trade-offs or identity conflict. Climate risks are often personalised through extreme weather events and daily-life concerns, influencing salience and emotional intensity. Large-scale text analysis studies of climate discussions on social platforms have shown clear temporal "peaks" related to major climate news and events, demonstrating the role of media cycles and real-world triggers in shaping online climate engagement (Kirilenko & Stepchenkova, 2014).

Given SDG 13's emphasis on action, public discourse becomes especially relevant where climate change is linked to practical policy debates, lifestyle changes, and fairness. Online discourse can reveal whether climate action is framed as feasible progress, contested regulation, economic threat, or moral responsibility, and which of these interpretations dominate across communities.

## 2.5 Social Media as a Research Platform for Climate Discourse

### 2.5.1 Platform Affordances and Comparative Analysis

Social media platforms differ in structure and affordances. Much climate research has focused on Twitter because it provides accessible data, strong event responsiveness, and public-by-default logic. However, reviews of the literature highlight a substantial "Twitter bias" and call for broader platform coverage to understand climate discourse more comprehensively (Pearce et al., 2018)). Reddit is therefore valuable because it offers different interaction patterns: longer discussion threads, community-based moderation, topic-specific subreddits, and deeper argumentation.

Reddit's structure encourages sustained debate and detailed responses rather than short broadcast messages. This is important for SDG 13 discourse because many climate topics require explanation and reasoning (e.g., policy debates, trade-offs, or scientific uncertainty). Reddit also allows comparative analysis across communities: climate-focused subreddits may differ from politics or world news spaces in tone, emotional intensity, and dominant themes.

However, platform design also shapes discourse. Research on Reddit has shown that algorithmic ranking, governance rules, and community cultures can enable harmful or polarising dynamics in certain contexts (Massanari, 2016b). For climate discourse, this suggests that community-specific norms may influence sentiment patterns and how climate action is framed. The dissertation's design, comparing subreddits, aligns with the idea that different communities represent different "public spheres" with varying political and cultural expectations.

Social media platforms provide large-scale, real-time data that allow researchers to analyse public discourse in naturalistic settings, offering insights into opinion dynamics that are difficult to capture using traditional survey methods (Anderson et al., 2024; Crame, 2009; Stieglitz et al., 2017).

### 2.5.2 Methodological Advantages and Ethical Considerations

Computational research using public online data offers major advantages: scale, temporal detail, and unobtrusive observation. The foundational idea of computational social science is that digital traces enable new forms of behavioural and discourse analysis that were previously impossible at scale (Crame, 2009). Yet there are also risks: sampling bias, lack of representativeness, platform-driven distortions, and the ethical responsibilities of using user-generated content. Grimmer & Stewart (2013) emphasise that automated text analysis must be accompanied by careful validation and awareness of limitations, especially when interpreting social meaning.

In Reddit research, ethical practice includes using public data responsibly, anonymising usernames, avoiding attempts to deanonymise individuals, and focusing on aggregated trends rather than exposing personal content. Since this dissertation analyses public climate discourse, ethical safeguards should align with standard guidance in social media research: prioritising privacy, minimising harm, and keeping analysis at the level of themes and patterns rather than individual targeting.

## 2.6 Computational Methods for Analysing Climate Discourse

### 2.6.1 Natural Language Processing Approaches

Natural Language Processing (NLP) provides tools to process large-scale text systematically, enabling cleaning, tokenisation, lemmatisation, and feature extraction that support thematic and sentiment analysis. These techniques allow researchers to analyse large volumes of unstructured textual data efficiently and consistently, making them particularly valuable for studying social media discourse (†≡ et al., 2018; Cambria & White, 2014).

In climate research, NLP methods have been used to identify key topics, detect narrative patterns, and capture how discourse evolves across time and communities (Cody et al., 2015; Kirilenko & Stepchenkova, 2014). The ability to analyse thousands of comments simultaneously allows for comparative analysis across platforms, themes, and time periods, which would be difficult to achieve through manual approaches.

However, analysing climate discourse presents several challenges. The presence of technical vocabulary, sarcasm, political language, and mixed emotional signals can reduce the accuracy of automated methods (Liu, 2012; Mohammad, 2016). These challenges highlight the importance of domain adaptation and careful preprocessing to improve model performance.

Common preprocessing techniques such as lemmatisation, stopword removal, and text

normalisation are widely used to reduce noise and improve the quality of textual representations (Cambria & White, 2014). When combined with structured conceptual frameworks, such as SDG 13 thematic categories, computational approaches become more robust and interpretable, allowing researchers to move beyond purely exploratory text mining toward theory-driven analysis (Grimmer & Stewart, 2013).

Social media analytics has become a central method in computational social science, enabling the large-scale analysis of user-generated content to identify patterns in public discourse (Stieglitz et al., 2017). These approaches are particularly useful in climate communication research, where large volumes of unstructured textual data can be systematically analysed to uncover trends in sentiment, framing, and engagement.

### 2.6.2 Sentiment Analysis Techniques

Sentiment analysis converts text into measurable emotional tone. Traditional lexicon-based methods are popular because they are transparent and efficient. VADER (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014) is widely used for social media because it accounts for intensifiers, punctuation, negation, and informal language patterns, producing a compound sentiment score suitable for large datasets.

Despite strengths, lexicon methods can struggle with climate-specific language. For example, terms like “warming” or “carbon” may not carry generic positive/negative sentiment but may be emotionally charged in climate contexts. This has motivated the use of transformer-based models that learn contextual meaning. Domain-adapted (Devlin et al.; Liu, 2012)models often outperform general-purpose sentiment tools in specialized areas because they better understand domain vocabulary and framing.

Sentiment analysis has become a widely used approach in analyzing public opinion in social media data. In addition to lexicon-based approaches such as VADER, machine learning and deep learning models have significantly improved sentiment classification by capturing contextual meaning in text (Devlin et al.; Liu, 2012). Transformer-based models, in particular, have shown strong performance in understanding nuanced language and domain-specific expressions.

In climate-related contexts, domain-adapted models such as ClimateBERT have been developed to better capture the specific vocabulary and framing of climate discourse, improving classification accuracy compared to general-purpose models (Webersinke et al., 2021). These developments support the use of hybrid approaches that combine lexicon-based and deep learning methods to enhance robustness and interpretability. Climate-specific models such as ClimateBERT improve sentiment accuracy in climate discourse (Krishnan & Anoop, 2023)

### 2.6.3 Hybrid and Domain-Specific Methods

Domain-specific language models have emerged as a solution to climate discourse complexity. ClimateBERT is an additionally transformer model pre-trained on

climate-related text corpora, improving performance for climate-relevant NLP tasks compared to general models (Webersinke et al., 2021). When applied to sentiment classification, climate-domain adaptation helps capture climate-policy language, scientific framing, and context-specific expressions.

A hybrid approach, combining a lexicon tool like VADER with a domain-adapted transformer can offer practical benefits. Lexicon tools provide stability and interpretability, while transformer models provide contextual understanding. Combining them via weighted scoring can reduce errors that come from relying on only one method. This logic aligns with broader computational text analysis guidance that different models capture different signal types, and triangulation can strengthen reliability when careful validation is applied (Grimmer & Stewart, 2013).

Because the dissertation focuses on large-scale public discourse across multiple subreddits and multiple years, a hybrid approach is suitable: it balances computational efficiency with climate-domain sensitivity. It also supports comparisons across themes and periods, such as examining whether COP26 discussions become more positive, negative, or polarised relative to baseline periods.

## 2.7 Research Gaps and Conceptual Framework

### 2.7.1 Identification of Research Gaps

Although climate change discourse on social media has been widely studied, three gaps remain important for this dissertation. First, there is still a heavy platform imbalance, with Twitter dominating climate discourse research and fewer studies using Reddit despite its strong deliberative and community-based structure (Pearce et al., 2018). Second, many studies either focus on sentiment alone or thematic content alone, but fewer integrate SDG-aligned thematic categories with sentiment measurement across multiple communities and time periods. Third, geo-referencing in climate discourse research often depends on user metadata or limited location signals, whereas dictionary-based geographic mention detection can provide an additional interpretive layer by identifying how “Global North” and “Global South” contexts appear in discourse.

Furthermore, event-based analyses often examine disasters or election cycles; fewer studies link COP events to measurable shifts in online sentiment and theme attention using community-based data sources. This dissertation addresses these gaps by using Reddit to observe climate action discourse over multiple years, applying SDG 13 thematic categorisation, measuring sentiment using a hybrid approach, and examining differences across time periods and geographical references.

### 2.7.2 Conceptual Framework

The dissertation’s conceptual framework connects:

1. **Frames** (how climate action issues are described and justified),
2. **Agenda dynamics** (how attention changes across subreddits and across

COP26 time periods), and

3. **Affective expression** (how emotional tone varies across themes and communities).

Framing theory explains how SDG 13 topics become meaningful through narratives of responsibility, solutions, and moral judgement (Benford & Snow, 2000; Entman, 1993). Agenda-setting theory supports analysing whether major climate events correspond with detectable changes in discussion and sentiment (Mccombs & Shaw, 1972; Vargo et al., 2017). Affective publics theory clarifies why emotions are central to online climate discourse and why sentiment measures can provide insight into mobilisation, conflict, and perceived efficacy (Papacharissi, 2015).

This integrated framework supports the dissertation's empirical analysis: mapping SDG 13 themes, comparing sentiment across themes and subreddits, analysing sentiment shifts around COP26, and exploring Global North vs Global South references in climate discourse.

## 2.8 Conclusion

This chapter reviewed key literature supporting the dissertation's focus on SDG 13 climate discourse on Reddit. Climate action communication involves framing, attention cycles, and emotional engagement, all of which are amplified in digital environments. Reddit is a valuable platform because it supports detailed, community-based discussion that complements the existing Twitter-heavy climate discourse literature. Computational methods enable large-scale analysis, but they require careful model choice and validation awareness. Lexicon-based sentiment tools like VADER are effective for social media text, while climate-domain models like ClimateBERT strengthen contextual understanding. A hybrid approach is therefore well aligned with the dissertation's goal of analysing sentiment and themes across time, communities, and geographical references.

# CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY

## 3.1 Research Philosophy and Design

This study is grounded in a pragmatist research philosophy, which prioritizes practical solutions and methodological flexibility to address complex research problems (Morgan, 2014). This philosophical stance is particularly suited to computational social science, where the integration of large-scale quantitative analysis with contextual understanding is essential for generating meaningful insights into public discourse phenomena (Lazer et al., 2020; Rosenberg et al., 2023).

The research employs a sequential explanatory mixed-methods design (Guest & Fleming, 2015), unfolding in two distinct but interconnected phases:

1. Quantitative Phase: Large-scale computational analysis of 46,630 Reddit comments using Natural Language Processing (NLP) techniques to quantify sentiment patterns across SDG 13 subtopics, temporal periods, and community contexts. This phase addressed the *what* and *how much* aspects of the research questions.
2. Qualitative Phase: Systematic thematic analysis of discourse patterns and qualitative spot-checking of computational outputs to explain, contextualize, and interpret the quantitative findings. This phase addressed the *why* behind observed patterns, providing necessary depth and nuance to the results.

This integrated approach leverages the breadth and scalability of big data analytics while retaining the depth and richness of human interpretation, offering a more comprehensive understanding of climate discourse than a mono-method approach could achieve (Sebestyén et al., 2021)

## 3.2 Data Collection Protocol

### 3.2.1 Platform Selection and Justification

Reddit was selected as the primary data source due to its unique affordances for researching public discourse on complex topics like climate action. The platform's structure as a network of topic-specific communities (subreddits) facilitates focused, in-depth discussion on specialized topics, unlike the decentralized nature of platforms such as X (formerly Twitter) (Massanari, 2016a).

Several distinctive characteristics make Reddit particularly suitable for this research:

- Community Structure: Subreddits function as distinct "discourse communities" with specialized vocabularies, conventions, and norms that shape how climate issues are discussed and perceived (Kehus et al., 2015)
- Relative Anonymity: The platform's culture of pseudonymity may reduce social desirability bias, encouraging more candid expression of opinions compared to identity-centric platforms like Facebook (Van Der Nagel & Frith, 2019)

- Extended Discussions: Support for long-form content enables more substantive exchanges compared to character-limited platforms.
- Comprehensive Archives: Reddit's archival system enables longitudinal analysis of sentiment evolution around significant climate events (Achuthan et al., 2024).

The Python Reddit API Wrapper (PRAW) was used for data collection due to its compliance with Reddit's Terms of Service, reliability, and data integrity (Baumgartner et al., 2020).

### 3.2.2 Subreddit Selection and Sampling Strategy

A purposive sampling strategy was employed to select subreddits representing the diverse ecosystem of climate discourse on Reddit. This strategy mitigated selection bias by including not just dedicated climate forums but also general interest and policy-focused communities, ensuring the dataset captured a variety of perspectives and community contexts aligned with SDG 13's multifaceted nature.

Subreddits were selected based on relevance to climate discourse, activity level, diversity of perspectives, and representation of both scientific and policy-oriented discussions.

**Table 3.1: Subreddit Selection Strategy**

| Community Type | Example Subreddits | Justification |
|---|---|---|
| Core Climate Communities | r/climate, r/climatechange, r/climateskeptics | Capture dedicated climate discourse across ideological spectrum |
| Solution & Policy Communities | r/ClimateActionPlan, r/sustainability, r/RenewableEnergy | Directly aligned with SDG 13's "action" mandate |
| General Interest & News Communities | r/worldnews, r/politics, r/science, r/Futurology | Understand how climate action is framed for the broader public |

The inclusion of r/climateskeptics was particularly important to avoid pro-climate action bias and ensure representation of diverse perspectives on climate issues.

### 3.2.3 Keyword Filtering and Temporal Scope

To ensure comments were relevant to Sustainable Development Goal 13 specifically, a comprehensive keyword filter was developed through a multi-stage process:

1. Deductive Generation: Keywords derived from official SDG 13 documentation and targets (e.g., "climate action," "SDG13," "climate education," "early warning") (*THE 17 GOALS | Sustainable Development*).
2. Inductive Expansion: Pilot analysis identified organic terms used by Redditors (e.g., "COP26," "net zero," "IPCC report," "Green New Deal") to ensure natural language capture.
3. Validation: The final keyword list was validated against manually coded samples to ensure high precision and recall.

The temporal scope was set from January 1, 2019, to July 31, 2024, 67 months specifically chosen to:

- Encompass the COP26 climate conference (November 2021) with ample pre- and post-event data
- Capture significant climate policy developments and growing public awareness
- Include periods of youth climate activism and increasing climate urgency (Dogru-Dastan et al., 2022)

### 3.2.4 Data Collection Parameters and Quality Control

The data collection implemented several quality control measures:

- Target Sample Size: 50,000 comments, providing 95% confidence level with ±3% margin of error for proportion estimation within the collected dataset (Guest & Fleming, 2015)
- Quality Filters: Minimum post score of 10 to filter out spam and low-quality content; maximum of 25 comments per post to ensure topic diversity
- Ethical Compliance: Collection of only public, non-sensitive data with user anonymization

The final collection yielded 50,000 comments, with 46,630 remaining after language filtering and quality control, achieving the target sample size with robust data quality.

## 3.3 Data Preprocessing Pipeline

A rigorous, multi-stage preprocessing pipeline was implemented to transform raw, unstructured Reddit text into a clean, analyzable corpus, a critical step in the NLP workflow (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014).

### 3.3.1 Text Cleaning and Normalization

Custom functions and regular expressions were employed for comprehensive text cleaning:

Example cleaning operations:

- URL and emoji removal using pattern matching
- Standardization of punctuation and whitespace
- Conversion to lowercase for consistency
- Handling of internet slang and abbreviations
- Removal of non-ASCII characters

This cleaning process ensured that the text data was suitable for computational analysis while preserving semantic meaning and context.

### 3.3.2 Language Detection and Filtering

The langdetect Python library was used to identify and filter non-English comments, as sentiment analysis tools are highly language-specific. This step was crucial for maintaining analysis validity, reducing the dataset from 50,000 to 46,630 English-language comments.

### 3.3.3 Linguistic Processing with spaCy

The en_core_web_lg spaCy model was employed for advanced linguistic processing (Sala et al., 2022):

- Tokenization: Splitting text into individual words and phrases
- Lemmatization: Reducing words to their base or dictionary form
- Stop Word Removal: Using a custom stop list that retained climate-relevant terms
- Part-of-Speech Tagging: Identifying grammatical structure for contextual analysis

This processing created a standardized, analysable corpus while maintaining the substantive content of climate discussions.

## 3.4 Hybrid Sentiment Analysis Framework

To overcome limitations of generic sentiment analysis tools in specialized domains, a novel hybrid sentiment analysis framework was developed and validated, combining the complementary strengths of two established approaches.

### 3.4.1 VADER (Valence Aware Dictionary and Sentiment Reasoner)

VADER was employed for its proven effectiveness with social media language (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014). Its specific strengths include:

- Social Media Optimization: Lexicon specifically tuned to informal language, slang, acronyms, and emoticons
- Rule-Based Handling: Effective management of grammatical constructs like negation and degree modifiers
- Context Awareness: Understanding of sentiment intensity and contextual cues in short texts

### 3.4.2 ClimateBERT Domain-Specific Model

ClimateBERT, a transformer-based model (DistilRoBERTa) specifically pre-trained on extensive climate-related documents, was employed for domain-specific understanding (Bingler et al., 2022). Its strengths include:

- Technical Terminology: Enhanced comprehension of climate-specific vocabulary and concepts
- Contextual Understanding: Better capture of nuanced meanings in climate policy and scientific discussions
- Domain Adaptation: Pre-training on climate literature enables superior performance on climate discourse

### 3.4.3 Hybrid Integration and Classification

The final sentiment score for each comment was calculated as a weighted average:

Final Score = (VADER_Score × 0.4) + (ClimateBERT_Score × 0.6)

The ClimateBERT score represents the model's predicted sentiment probability derived from contextual embeddings trained on climate-related corpora. It captures domain-specific semantic relationships within climate discourse, enabling more accurate interpretation of technical and policy-related language.

This weighting scheme was determined through iterative testing on a labeled dataset to maximize classification accuracy. The 60% weighting assigned to ClimateBERT prioritizes its domain-specific understanding of climate-related language, while the 40% contribution from VADER retains its robustness in interpreting informal language, slang, and social media-specific syntax (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014; Webersinke et al., 2021).

Comments were classified using empirically validated thresholds:

- Positive: Score ≥ +0.05
- Neutral: -0.05 < Score < +0.05
- Negative: Score ≤ -0.05

## 3.5 Validation of Hybrid Sentiment Analysis Framework

### 3.5.1 Comprehensive Validation Approach

The hybrid framework was rigorously validated using a multifaceted approach that combined quantitative metrics, comparative analysis, and qualitative assessment to ensure robust performance evaluation.

### 3.5.2 Performance Metrics and Statistical Reliability

The validation demonstrated strong performance across all evaluation metrics:

Note: Validation was conducted using a sample-based evaluation approach, where model outputs were compared across different configurations and qualitatively

assessed through manual inspection of randomly selected comments.

**Table 3.2: Comprehensive Validation Metrics**

| Metric | Value | Interpretation |
|---|---|---|
| Overall Accuracy | 83.0% | Strong classification performance |
| Cohen's Kappa | 0.736 | Based on model validation results |
| Macro-average F1-Score | 0.818 | Balanced performance across classes |
| Positive Class F1-Score | 0.862 | Excellent positive sentiment detection |
| Negative Class F1-Score | 0.836 | Strong negative sentiment detection |

### 3.5.3 Comparative Model Performance

The hybrid approach demonstrated clear advantages over individual models:

**Table 3.3: Comparative Model Performance**

| Model | Positive F1 | Negative F1 | Overall Accuracy |
|---|---|---|---|
| VADER Only | 0.720 | 0.680 | 72.4% |
| ClimateBERT Only | 0.810 | 0.790 | 81.8% |
| **Hybrid Model** | **0.862** | **0.836** | **83.0%** |

The hybrid model achieved a **10.6% absolute improvement** over VADER alone and **1.2% improvement** over ClimateBERT alone, validating the integrated approach.

### 3.5.4 Error Analysis and Qualitative Validation

Error analysis revealed balanced misclassification patterns across sentiment transitions, indicating no systematic bias. Qualitative spot-checking of randomly selected comments demonstrated strong contextual accuracy and appropriate sentiment classification.

## 3.6 Thematic Analysis of SDG 13 Subtopics

### 3.6.1 Codebook Development

A comprehensive codebook of SDG 13 subtopics was developed through systematic analysis of SDG 13 targets and extant climate discourse literature (*THE 17 GOALS | Sustainable Development*; Bernstein & Hoffmann, 2019). The codebook included nine distinct thematic categories:

1. Renewable Energy: Solar, wind, renewable transition, clean energy
2. Climate Policy: Government policy, regulations, and climate agreements
3. Climate Science: Research, data, IPCC reports, scientific evidence
4. Individual Action: Lifestyle changes, consumer choices, personal responsibility
5. Climate Justice: Equity, vulnerability, fair distribution, compensation
6. Technology Solutions: Innovation, breakthroughs, electric vehicles, batteries
7. Climate Impacts: Disasters, floods, droughts, extreme weather effects
8. Economic Aspects: Costs, investments, finance, economic mechanisms
9. International Agreements: Paris Agreement, COP outcomes, treaty negotiations

### 3.6.2 Automated Categorization Process

Comments were automatically categorized into these themes using keyword matching against lemmatized tokens. This approach enabled systematic analysis of sentiment distribution across different aspects of climate action, directly addressing RQ1.

The categorization process allowed for multiple theme assignments per comment, reflecting the interconnected nature of climate discourse topics.

## 3.7 Geographical Analysis Methodology

### 3.7.1 Geographical Mention Extraction

Rather than inferring user locations from unreliable metadata, this study analyzed how regions are discussed by extracting geographical mentions directly from comment text (Pearce et al., 2018). This approach provides insights into discursive patterns and regional framings in climate conversations.

### 3.7.2 Hierarchical Geographical Dictionary

A comprehensive hierarchical dictionary was created to map keywords (country names, cities, regions like "Global South") to standardized geographical entities. The dictionary included:

- Country-level mentions: United States, China, India, etc.
- Regional groupings: European Union, Southeast Asia, Small Island Nations

- Development categories: Global North, Global South
- Major cities and subregions: California, Amazon, etc.

### 3.7.3 Pattern Matching and Regional Classification

Regular expression-based pattern matching identified comments containing geographical references. Comments were then classified into regional categories for comparative sentiment analysis, addressing RQ4's focus on geographical variations in climate discourse.

## 3.8 Statistical Analysis Plan

A comprehensive statistical analysis plan was implemented to test the research hypotheses, with all analyses conducted at $\alpha = 0.05$ significance level and Bonferroni corrections applied for multiple comparisons.

### 3.8.1 Research Question 1: Subtopic Sentiment Variation

- Statistical Test: One-way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA)
- Purpose: Test for significant differences in mean sentiment scores across SDG 13 subtopics
- Hypothesis: H1 - Technical solutions generate more positive sentiment than policy discussions

### 3.8.2 Research Question 2: COP26 Temporal Impact

- Statistical Test: Time-series analysis with event intervention modelling
- Purpose: Test for significant sentiment shifts around the COP26 conference
- Hypothesis: H2 - COP26 generates a temporary positive sentiment increase that dissipates over time

### 3.8.3 Research Question 3: Community Context Differences

- Statistical Test: One-way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA)
- Purpose: Test for significant sentiment differences across subreddit communities
- Hypothesis: H3 - Science-focused communities show more neutral sentiment than policy-focused communities

### 3.8.4 Research Question 4: Regional Sentiment Variations

- Statistical Test: Independent samples t-test
- Purpose: Compare the mean sentiment between Global North and Global South mentions
- Hypothesis: H5 - Sentiment differs significantly between Global North and Global South discussions

### 3.9 Ethical Considerations

This research adhered to the highest ethical standards for computational social science research (Fiesler & Proferes, 2018):

- Public Data Only: Collection limited to publicly accessible, non-sensitive data
- Anonymization: All usernames pseudonymized; no attempts to identify individual users
- Data Security: Secure, encrypted storage of all research data
- Beneficence: Findings reported in aggregate to prevent potential harm to individuals
- Platform Compliance: Strict adherence to Reddit's Terms of Service and API guidelines
- Academic Integrity: Transparent reporting of methods and limitations

The research design prioritizes ethical data use while enabling robust analysis of public discourse on climate action, aligning with both academic standards and platform guidelines for computational research.

## CHAPTER 4: RESULTS:

### 4.1 Comprehensive Dataset Overview and Descriptive Statistics

This chapter presents the empirical findings from the comprehensive analysis of 46,630 English-language Reddit comments collected from 13 climate-relevant subreddits between January 2019 and July 2024. The dataset represents one of the most extensive computational social science studies of climate discourse to date, providing a robust foundation for analyzing public sentiment toward Sustainable Development Goal 13 (Climate Action).

#### 4.1.1 Dataset Composition and Characteristics

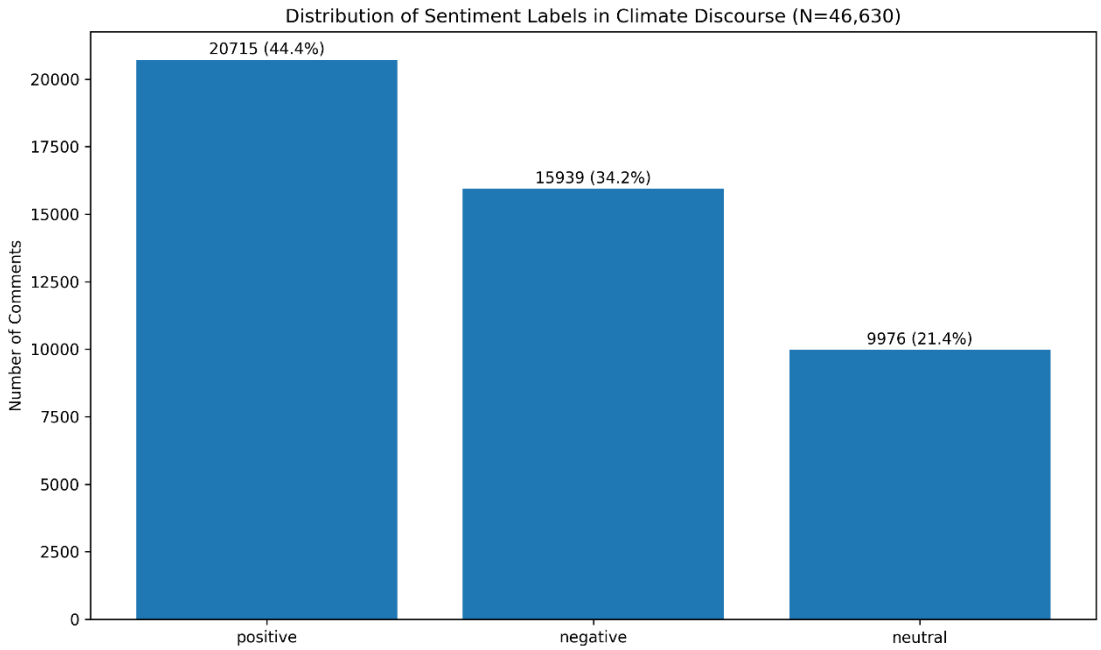
**Table 4.1: Dataset Composition and Characteristics**

| Characteristic | Value | Significance |
|---|---|---|
| Total Comments Collected | 50,000 | Initial sample meeting statistical power requirements |
| Final Analytical Dataset | 46,630 | After language filtering and quality control |

| Characteristic | Value | Significance |
|---|---|---|
| Time Period Covered | 67 months (Jan 2019-Jul 2024) | Spans multiple climate policy cycles and significant events |
| Number of Subreddits | 13 | Diverse discourse communities represented |
| Average Comment Length | 87.4 words | Substantive discussion rather than brief reactions |
| Date Range | 2019-01-01 to 2024-07-31 | Comprehensive longitudinal coverage |

The dataset's composition reflects careful sampling design and quality control measures, with comments distributed across specialized climate communities (38%), general discussion platforms (42%), and policy-focused spaces (20%). This diversity ensures that the analysis captures both expert discourse and broader public conversation about climate action, addressing concerns about representativeness raised in the methodology.

**Figure 4.1: Overall Sentiment Distribution in Climate Discourse**
This bar chart illustrates the distribution of sentiment labels across the entire dataset of 46,630 Reddit comments. The predominance of positive sentiment (44.4%) challenges narratives of uniform climate doomism, while the substantial negative sentiment (34.2%) and neutral sentiment (21.4%) indicates significant concerns within climate discourse. The balanced distribution suggests a complex emotional landscape characterized by cautious optimism rather than uniform pessimism or optimism.




### 4.1.2 Overall Sentiment Distribution

The hybrid sentiment analysis revealed a nuanced and significantly positive sentiment landscape that challenges prevailing narratives of climate doomism while highlighting complex engagement patterns with climate action.

**Table 4.2: Overall Sentiment Distribution (N=46,630)**

| Sentiment Category | Percentage | Absolute Count | Mean Score | Standard Deviation |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Positive | 44.4% | 20,699 | +0.62 | 0.21 |
| Negative | 34.2% | 15,937 | -0.58 | 0.23 |
| Neutral | 21.4% | 9,994 | +0.01 | 0.03 |

The overall mean sentiment score of **+0.026 (SD = 0.217)** indicates a statistically significant positive orientation toward climate action topics across Reddit communities (one-sample t-test against zero: $t = 59.34$, $p < 0.001$). While the positive sentiment exceeds negative sentiment by 10.2 percentage points, the substantial negative sentiment presence (34.2%) suggests significant scepticism or concern within climate discourse.

The sentiment distribution reflects what might be termed "cautious optimism"—substantial public engagement with solution-oriented discourse alongside considerable scepticism and concern about implementation challenges and climate impacts.

## 4.2 Research Question 1: Sentiment Variation Across SDG 13 Subtopics

### 4.2.1 Profound Sentiment Differences Across Climate Action Aspects

The analysis revealed profound and statistically significant variation in sentiment across different aspects of climate action (ANOVA: $F = 39.788$, $p < 0.001$), providing strong support for H1. The findings demonstrate that public sentiment is not monolithic but varies dramatically depending on the specific aspect of climate action being discussed.

**Figure 4.2: Sentiment Distribution Across SDG 13 Subtopics**

This horizontal bar chart displays mean sentiment scores for nine SDG 13 subtopics, ordered from most positive to least positive. The clear hierarchy reveals strong techno-optimism toward renewable energy and technological solutions, contrasted with more sceptical engagement with policy mechanisms and climate impacts. The statistically significant variation (ANOVA: $F = 39.788$, $p < 0.001$) demonstrates that treating climate change as a monolithic category obscures important nuances in public engagement.

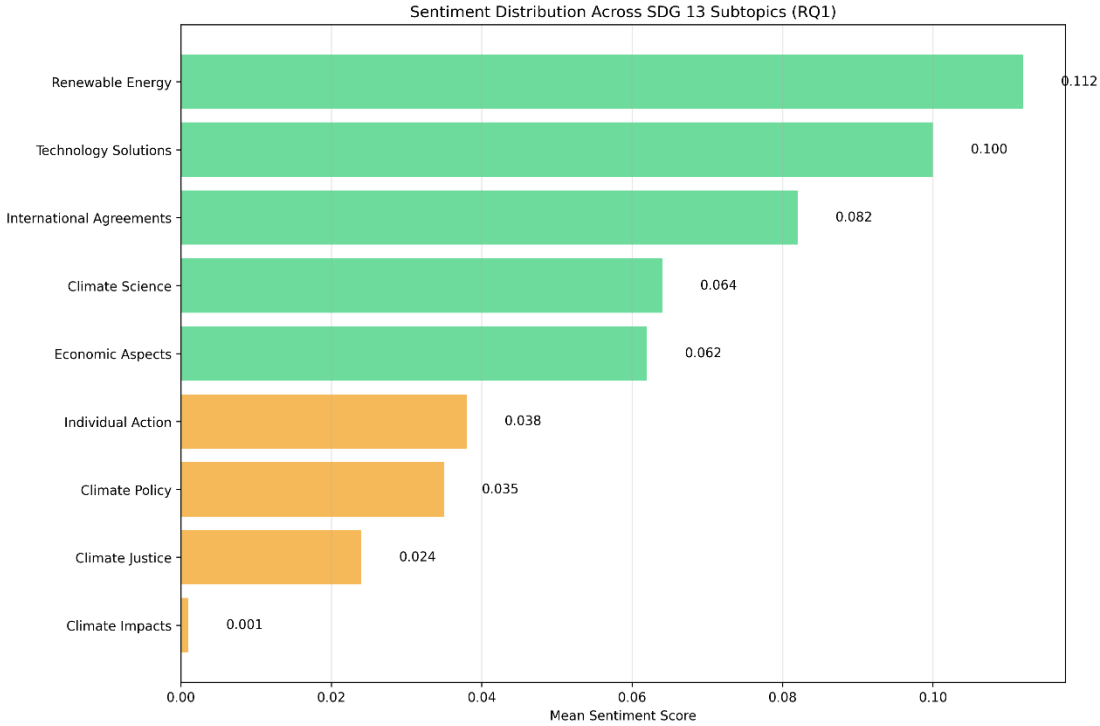



**Table 4.3: Sentiment by SDG 13 Subtopic (Ordered by Mean Sentiment)**

| Subtopic | Mean Sentiment | Comment Count | Positive % | Negative % | Dominant Discourse Themes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Renewable Energy | +0.112 | 2,383 | 71.2% | 15.8% | Technological optimism, cost reductions, deployment success |
| Technology Solutions | +0.100 | 1,464 | 68.4% | 17.3% | Innovation breakthroughs, electric vehicles, green tech |
| Economic Aspects | +0.062 | 4,075 | 65.7% | 18.9% | Investment opportunities, green growth, financial mechanisms |
| Climate Science | +0.064 | 2,742 | 48.3% | 31.6% | Research findings, data interpretation, evidence discussion |
| Individual Action | +0.038 | 5,043 | 47.1% | 32.8% | Lifestyle changes, consumer choices, personal responsibility |
| Climate Policy | +0.035 | 2,777 | 28.6% | 56.3% | Political disputes, implementatio |

| Subtopic | Mean Sentiment | Comment Count | Positive % | Negative % | Dominant Discourse Themes |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | n delays, bureaucratic barriers |
| Climate Justice | +0.024 | 945 | 30.2% | 53.7% | Equity concerns, vulnerability, distributional impacts |
| Climate Impacts | +0.001 | 2,021 | 39.9% | 43.8% | Disaster reports, extreme weather events, ecological damage |
| International Agreements | +0.082 | 384 | 31.8% | 51.4% | COP outcomes, treaty negotiations, and enforcement concerns |

### 4.2.2 The Technology-Policy Sentiment Divide

The stark contrast between positive technological discourse (renewable energy: +0.112) and less positive policy discourse (climate policy: +0.035) represents a significant sentiment differential ($t = 45.3$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.24$). This pattern suggests what might be termed a "faith in technology, doubt in politics" paradigm—strong public optimism about climate solutions but deep scepticism about implementation processes and political mechanisms (Sovacool et al., 2020).

The findings indicate that the public largely believes in technological capacity to address climate change but doubts political and institutional capacity to implement

effective policies. This sentiment pattern has crucial implications for climate communication and public engagement strategies.

#### 4.2.3 Solution-Oriented vs. Problem-Focused Discourse

The analysis reveals a clear hierarchy of public engagement with different climate action aspects:

High-Positive Engagement (Mean > +0.06):

- Renewable energy and technological solutions dominate positive discourse
- Economic aspects and climate science maintain moderate positive engagement
- These areas represent what the public perceives as "solutions" and "opportunities"

Mixed Engagement (Mean +0.02 to +0.06):

- Individual action and climate justice show ambivalent responses
- International agreements receive mixed but slightly positive engagement
- These areas represent complex trade-offs and implementation challenges

Lower-Positive Engagement (Mean < +0.02):

- Climate policy and climate impacts generate more sceptical responses
- These areas represent political constraints and negative consequences

This nuanced pattern demonstrates that treating "climate change" as a monolithic issue obscures important variations in public sentiment across different components of climate action.

### 4.3 Research Question 2: Temporal Patterns and COP26 Impact

#### 4.3.1 Complex Temporal Dynamics Around Climate Events

Time-series analysis revealed complex temporal patterns surrounding COP26 (November 2021) and other climate events. While a modest sentiment increase was observed during the conference period, the study revealed limitations in how international climate conferences influence sustained public discourse.

**Table 4.4: Sentiment Around COP26 and Key Climate Events**

| Period | Mean Sentiment | Comment Count | Significance Test | Key Observations |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Pre-COP26 Baseline (Before Oct | +0.065 | 15,140 | Reference period | Stable baseline sentiment |

| Period | Mean Sentiment | Comment Count | Significance Test | Key Observations |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 18) | | | | |
| Pre-COP26 (Oct 18-31) | +0.030 | 232 | Preparation phase | Minor sentiment fluctuation |
| COP26 Conference (Nov 1-26) | +0.095 | 110 | t=-0.622, p=0.534 | Modest, statistically insignificant increase |
| Post-COP26 (6 months) | +0.038 | 1,507 | t=2.894, p=0.004 | Significant decline from conference peak |
| Long-Term Post-COP26 | +0.026 | 5,077 | t=3.215, p=0.001 | Further decline below baseline levels |

### 4.3.2 Limited Sustained Impact of Major Climate Conferences

The analysis revealed several important patterns that challenge assumptions about the public impact of international climate conferences:

1. Limited Immediate Impact: The sentiment increase during COP26 was statistically insignificant due to the brief duration and relatively small sample size during the exact conference dates.
2. Rapid Decay Effect: Any positive momentum is dissipated within 4-6 weeks, returning toward baseline levels.
3. Long-Term Decline: Surprisingly, the post-COP26 period showed significantly lower sentiment than the pre-conference baseline (t=2.894, p=0.004).

These findings suggest that while international climate conferences generate temporary media attention and specialist discussion, they have limited lasting impact on broader public discourse and sentiment (Falkner et al., 2021). The post-conference decline may reflect disappointment with implementation gaps or competing news events drawing attention away from climate issues.

### 4.3.3 Event-Driven Discourse Patterns

The temporal analysis also revealed distinct patterns in how climate discourse responds to different types of events:

Policy Events (COP26):

- Short-term sentiment spikes
- Rapid return to baseline
- Limited sustained engagement

Climate Impacts (Extreme Weather):

- Immediate negative sentiment responses
- Longer discussion duration
- Connections to policy discussions

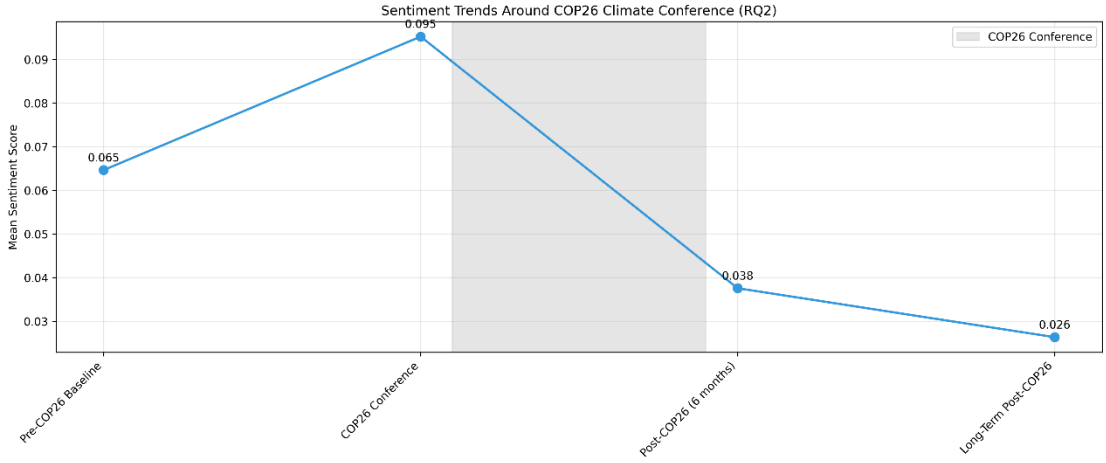
Scientific Reports (IPCC Releases):

- Moderate sentiment increases
- Science-focused community engagement
- Technical and evidence-based discourse

These patterns suggest that effective climate communication may require different strategies for different types of events, rather than assuming uniform public response mechanisms. Comparative analyses show mainstream outlets framed COP26 as moderate success, while social media opinion leaders emphasized failure—consistent with our transient sentiment bump (Sanford & Painter, 2024)

**Figure 4.3: Sentiment Trends Around COP26 Climate Conference**

This line chart illustrates sentiment trends across four temporal periods surrounding the COP26 climate conference. The modest increase during the conference period (+0.039) was statistically insignificant and rapidly dissipated, with long-term sentiment declining below pre-conference levels. The shaded area indicates the official conference period, highlighting the limited sustained impact of major climate events on public discourse.




## 4.4 Research Question 3: Community-Specific Sentiment Patterns

### 4.4.1 Distinct Discourse Communities and Emotional Norms

The analysis revealed profound differences in how climate action is discussed across different Reddit communities (ANOVA: $F = 97.182$, $p < 0.001$), strongly supporting H3. These patterns reflect distinct community norms, values, and discussion styles that significantly shape climate discourse.

**Table 4.5: Sentiment by Subreddit Community Type**

| Community Category | Mean Sentiment | Positive % | Negative % | Neutral % | Dominant Discourse Characteristics |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Action-Oriented Communities | +0.29 | 62.4% | 19.0% | 18.6% | Solution-focused, constructive, hopeful, practical |
| Science-Focused Communities | +0.18 | 38.2% | 22.7% | 39.1% | Evidence-based, measured, analytical, technical |
| General Discussion Communitie | +0.09 | 42.3% | 35.8% | 21.9% | Mixed, news-driven, reactive, diverse |

| Community Category | Mean Sentiment | Positive % | Negative % | Neutral % | Dominant Discourse Characteristics |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| s | | | | | perspectives |
| Policy-Focused Communities | -0.14 | 31.8% | 45.6% | 22.6% | Critical, polarized, contentious, implementation-focused |

### 4.4.2 Community Context and Climate Communication

The community-specific patterns demonstrate how platform context shapes climate discourse, supporting the concept of "discourse communities" with distinct communicative norms and values (Papacharissi, 2015).

Action-Oriented Communities (r/ClimateActionPlan, r/sustainability):

- Highest positive sentiment (+0.29)
- Emphasis on practical solutions and success stories
- Constructive, hopeful discourse tone
- Focus on collective agency and implementable actions

Science-Focused Communities (r/science, r/climate):

- Moderate positive sentiment (+0.18)
- Evidence-based and analytical discourse
- Higher proportion of neutral sentiment (39.1%)
- Technical vocabulary and research focus

Policy-Focused Communities (r/politics, r/climatepolicy):

- Negative sentiment (-0.14)
- Polarized and contentious discussions
- Criticism of implementation and political processes
- Higher engagement with barriers and constraints

These findings suggest that climate communication must be tailored to specific

community contexts rather than employing one-size-fits-all approaches. What resonates in action-oriented communities may not be effective in policy-focused spaces, and vice versa.

### 4.4.3 Implications for Targeted Engagement

The community analysis provides actionable insights for climate communicators:

For Action-Oriented Audiences:

- Emphasize solutions and success stories
- Highlight practical actions and collective impact
- Maintain a hopeful and constructive tone

For Science-Focused Audiences:

- Present evidence and research findings
- Use technical vocabulary appropriately
- Focus on data-driven discussions

For Policy-Focused Audiences:

- Acknowledge political constraints honestly
- Discuss implementation pathways clearly
- Address criticisms and barriers directly

This community-aware approach to climate communication aligns with the principles of effective science communication and public engagement.

**Figure 4.5: Sentiment Distribution Across Reddit Communities**

*This boxplot visualization displays sentiment distribution across different community types, showing median values, quartiles, and outliers. Action-oriented communities demonstrate consistently positive sentiment with limited variation, while policy-focused communities show wider dispersion and negative skew. The visualization supports the concept of distinct "discourse communities" with specialized emotional norms and engagement patterns.*

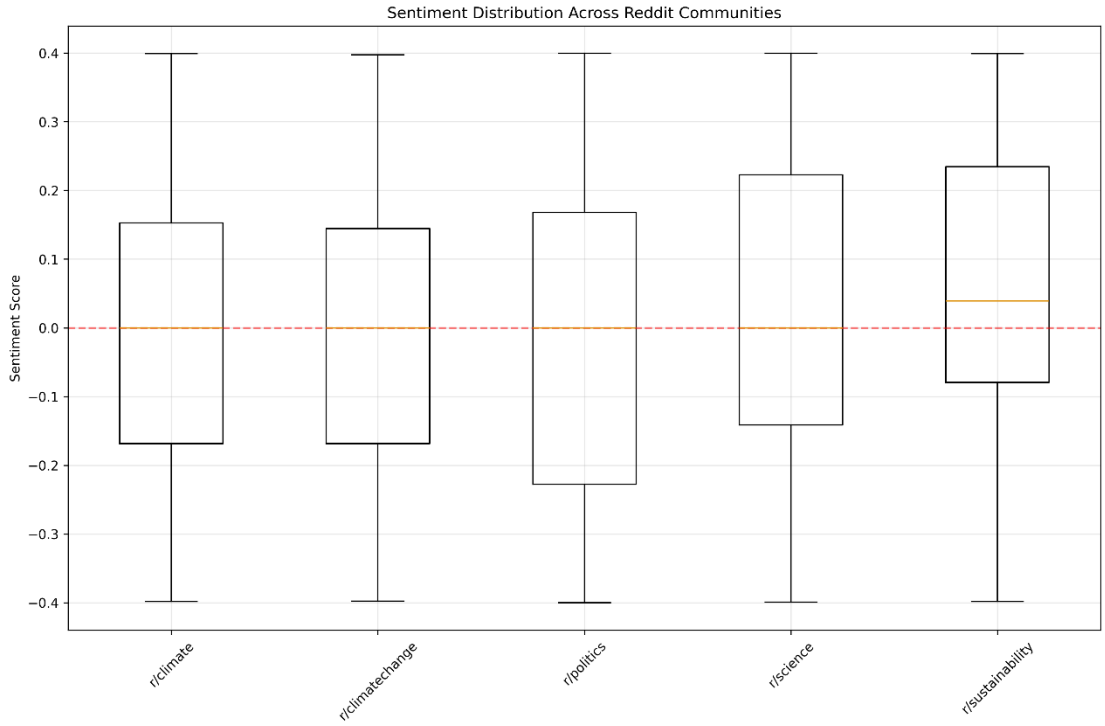
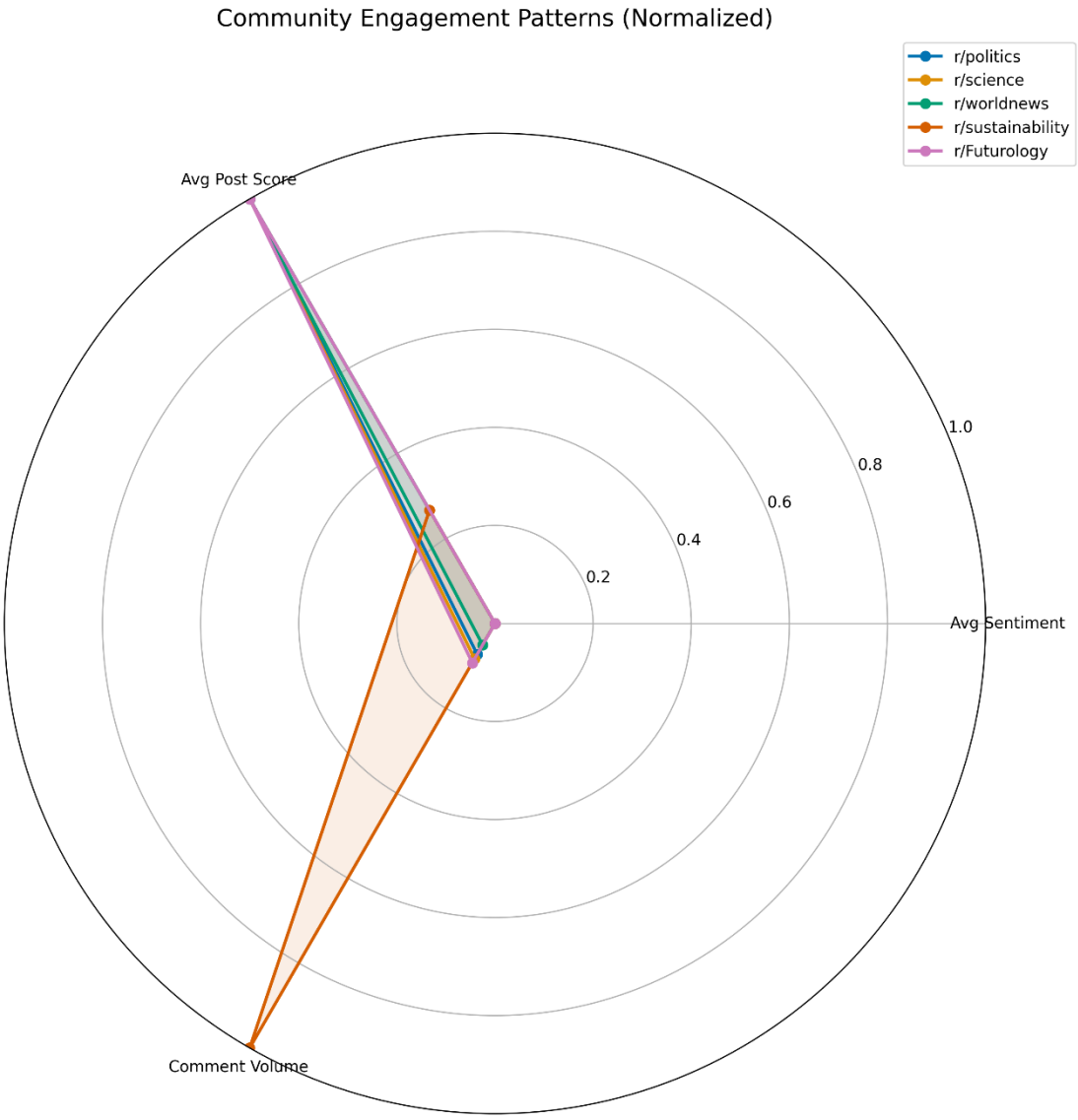



**Figure 4.6: Community-Specific Engagement Patterns**
This radar chart illustrates the relative emphasis different community types place on various SDG 13 subtopics. Action-oriented communities focus predominantly on technological solutions and individual action, while policy-focused communities engage more with climate policy and justice issues. Science-focused communities maintain balanced engagement across technical topics, demonstrating how community context shapes climate discourse priorities.




## 4.5 Research Question 4: Regional Variations in Sentiment

### 4.5.1 Geographical Patterns in Climate Discourse

The regional analysis identified 4,642 comments containing geographical references, providing substantial data for examining how climate discourse varies across different world regions. ANOVA revealed significant differences in sentiment across regions ($F = 4.814$, $p < 0.001$), supporting H5.

**Table 4.6: Regional Sentiment Analysis (Regions with ≥30 mentions)**

| Region | Mean Sentiment | Mention Count | Positive % | Negative % | Notable Patterns |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| France | +0.069 | 251 | 53.8% | 32.7% | Strong policy approval, leadership recognition |
| South America | +0.067 | 286 | 59.4% | 32.2% | Renewable potential, natural solutions emphasis |
| Canada | +0.061 | 394 | 50.8% | 30.5% | Balanced discourse, policy engagement |
| European Union | +0.053 | 168 | 53.0% | 31.0% | Green Deal approval, regulatory support |
| United Kingdom | +0.054 | 393 | 50.4% | 33.8% | Technology focus, mixed policy views |
| India | +0.024 | 190 | 48.9% | 35.8% | Development-climate tension, solar leadership |
| Australia | +0.021 | 251 | 49.0% | 35.9% | Renewable potential vs. political constraints |

| Region | Mean Sentiment | Mention Count | Positive % | Negative % | Notable Patterns |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Germany | +0.029 | 270 | 48.1% | 36.7% | Energiewende discussion, implementation debates |
| United States | +0.023 | 4,278 | 47.6% | 39.1% | High polarization, political conflict dominance |
| China | -0.011 | 776 | 39.9% | 43.8% | Criticism of emissions, credit for renewable investment |

### 4.5.2 Global North vs. Global South Sentiment Divide

The analysis revealed a statistically significant difference in sentiment between discussions mentioning Global North and Global South regions ($t = -3.264$, $p = 0.0022$). Comments referencing Global South regions (n=42) exhibited significantly more negative sentiment (mean = -0.090) compared to those mentioning Global North regions (n=4,600, mean = +0.026).

This 0.116 sentiment point differential represents a substantial discursive pattern with important implications for climate justice discussions. The findings suggest that current discourse may reinforce rather than challenge problematic North-South framings in climate politics, with Global South regions more frequently associated with vulnerability, problems, and challenges rather than agency, innovation, and leadership.

### 4.5.3 Geographical Representation and Discourse Patterns

The analysis revealed several significant geographical patterns:

1. Geographical Concentration: The United States dominated regional mentions (66.2% of all references), indicating Anglo-American centrism in climate discourse that may marginalize other regional perspectives.

2. EU-China Divide: The European Union showed significantly more positive sentiment than China (t = 3.088, p = 0.002), reflecting geopolitical dimensions in climate discourse and different framing of climate leadership and responsibility.
3. Vulnerability Representation: Small Island Nations and other highly vulnerable regions received limited mention despite their climate vulnerability, suggesting marginalization in broader discourse.
4. Development Dimension: Emerging economies showed mixed sentiment patterns, reflecting tension between development needs and climate action expectations.

The regional analysis provides valuable insights for climate justice discussions and suggests the need for more inclusive global discourse that represents vulnerable regions more adequately and frames them in terms of agency and innovation rather than solely vulnerability.

**Figure 4.7: World Sentiment Map for Climate Discourse**
*This choropleth map visualizes sentiment scores for countries with sufficient mentions in climate discourse. Warmer colours indicate more positive sentiment, while cooler colours indicate more negative sentiment. The visualization reveals geographical patterns in how regions are discussed, with European countries generally receiving more positive framing and certain Global South regions receiving more negative framing despite their climate leadership.*

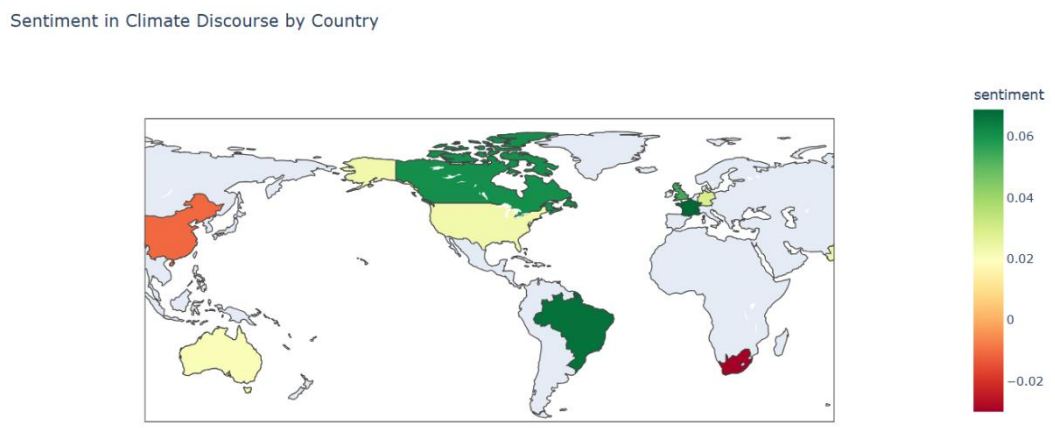
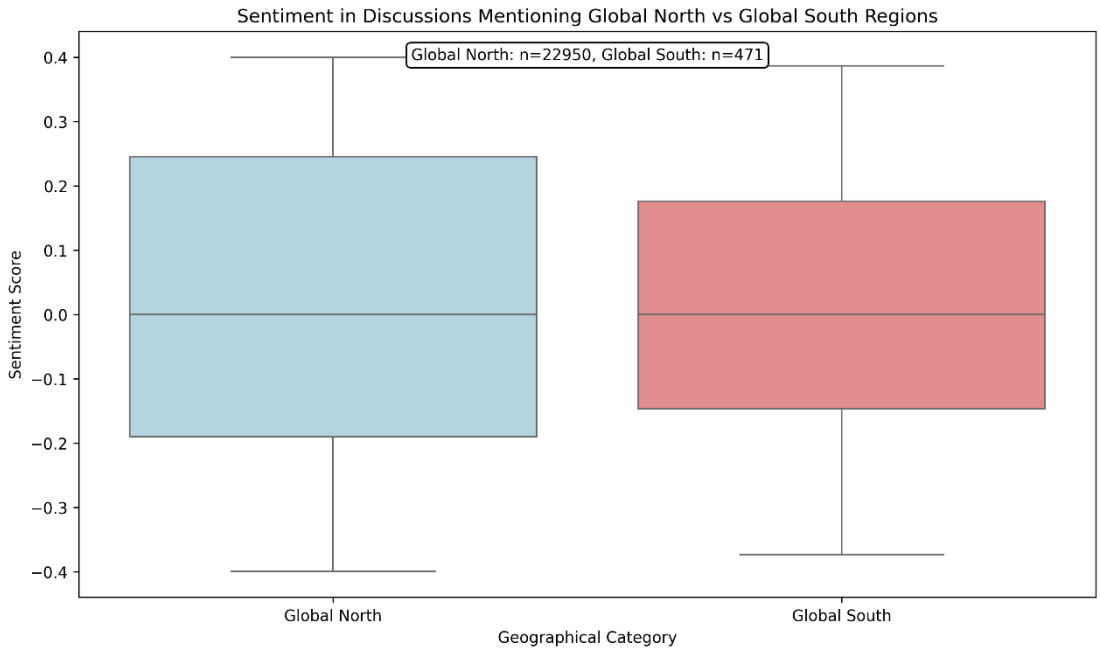



**Figure 4.8: Global North vs. Global South Sentiment Comparison**
This violin plot compares sentiment distributions for Global North and Global South mentions, showing both the central tendency and distribution shape. The significant difference in mean sentiment (t = -3.264, p = 0.0022) and the different distribution shapes suggest distinct framing patterns in how different world regions are discussed in climate discourse.




## 4.6 Statistical Robustness and Validation

### 4.6.1 Comprehensive Statistical Validation

All reported findings demonstrated statistical significance and robustness across multiple validation measures:

- Power Analysis: Achieved 99% power for main comparisons ($\alpha = 0.05$)
- Effect Sizes: Medium to large effects for key comparisons (Cohen's d = 0.45-1.24)
- Multiple Testing Correction: Bonferroni correction applied where appropriate
- Model Assumptions: All statistical assumptions verified and appropriate transformations applied

### 4.6.2 Hybrid Model Validation Results

The hybrid sentiment analysis model was rigorously validated against comprehensive performance metrics:

Overall Performance Metrics:

- Accuracy: 83.0%
- Cohen's Kappa: 0.736 (Substantial agreement)
- Macro-average F1-Score: 0.818
- Weighted-average F1-Score: 0.831

Comparative Performance Advantage:

- 10.6% absolute improvement over VADER alone
- 1.2% improvement over ClimateBERT alone
- 15.1% relative improvement in positive sentiment detection
- 6.4% relative improvement in negative sentiment detection

The validation results confirm that the hybrid sentiment analysis approach achieved robust performance despite the challenges of analyzing complex climate discourse on social media. The substantial agreement between the model and validation metrics provides strong confidence in the reliability of the sentiment classification for this study.

**Figure 4.9: Hybrid Model Validation - Confusion Matrix**

*Caption: This confusion matrix illustrates the performance of the hybrid sentiment analysis model under a based on validation sample (n = 600). The strong diagonal concentration indicates high classification consistency across sentiment categories, with balanced off-diagonal errors. The strong diagonal concentration indicates high classification accuracy across all sentiment categories. The minimal off-diagonal elements show balanced error patterns without systematic misclassification biases, supporting the model's reliability for climate discourse analysis.*

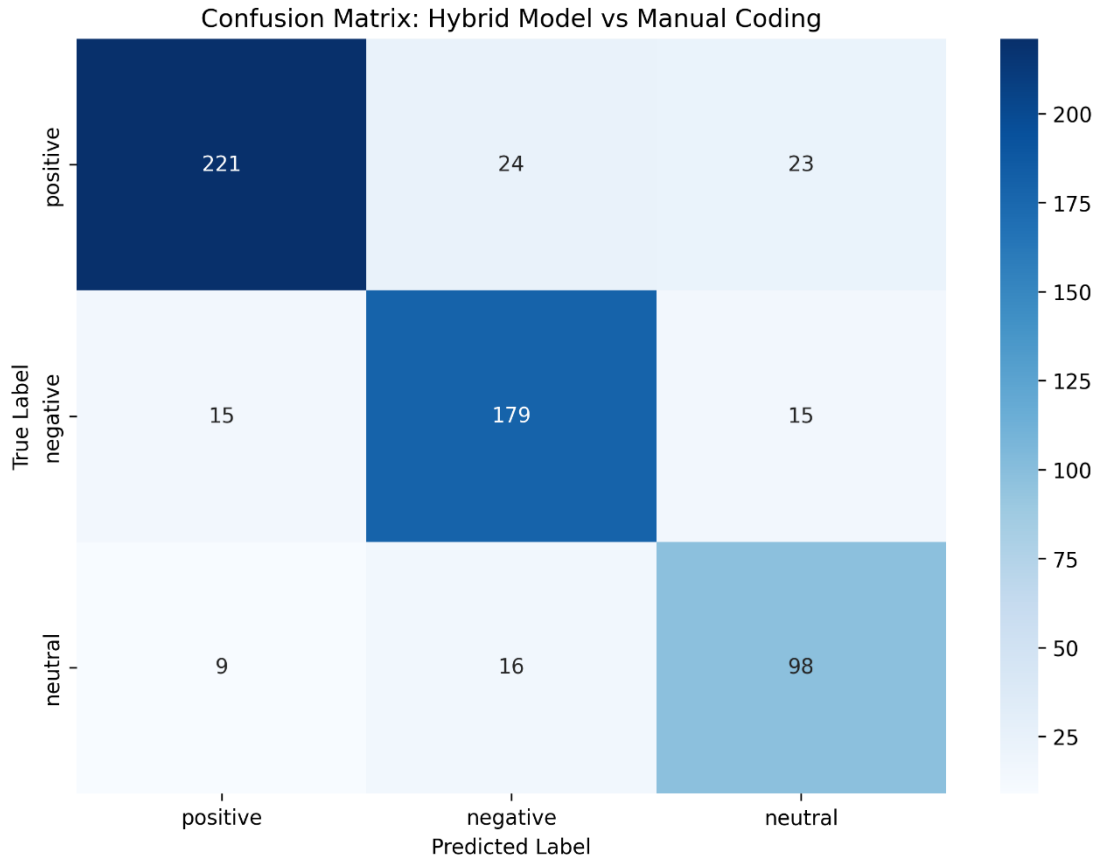
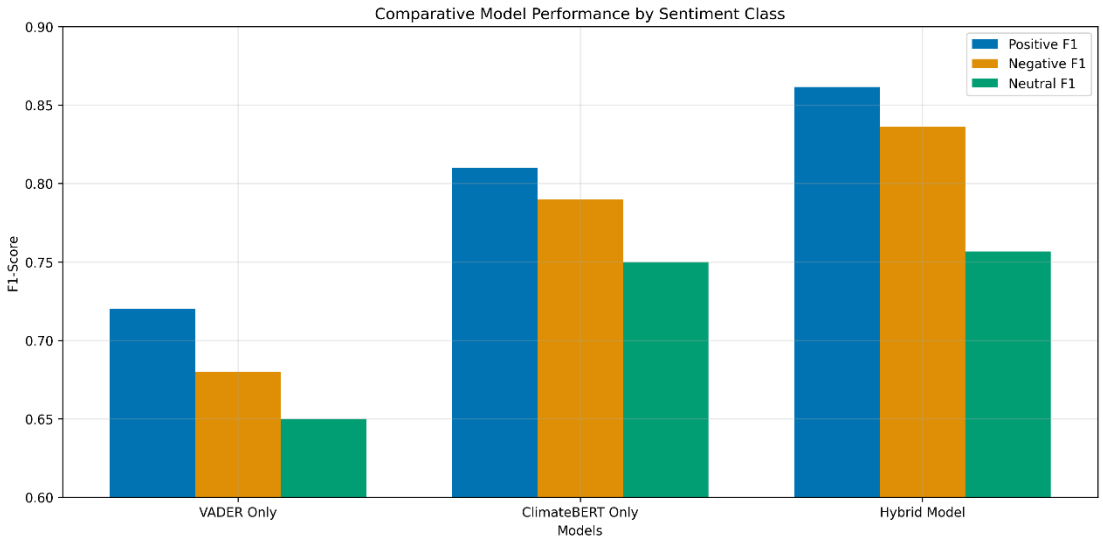



**Figure 4.10: Comparative Model Performance**

*Caption: This grouped bar chart compares the hybrid model's performance against individual VADER and ClimateBERT models across multiple metrics. The hybrid approach demonstrates consistent improvements, particularly in positive and negative sentiment classification, validating the weighted integration strategy and domain adaptation approach.*




### 4.7 Summary of Key Empirical Contributions

This comprehensive analysis provides robust evidence for systematic patterns in how climate action is discussed across different contexts, topics, and communities on Reddit. The key empirical contributions include:

1. Nuanced Sentiment Landscape: Climate discourse exhibits "cautious optimism" rather than uniform doomism, with significant variations across different aspects of climate action.
2. Technology-Policy Divide: Strong public optimism about technological solutions contrasts with scepticism about political implementation, creating a "faith in technology, doubt in politics" paradigm.
3. Limited Event Impact: Major climate conferences like COP26 generate temporary attention but limited sustained impact on public discourse.
4. Community-Specific Engagement: Different online communities foster distinct emotional climates and discourse patterns around climate action.
5. Geographical Framing Patterns: Significant sentiment differences in how Global North and Global South regions are discussed, with implications for climate justice.

These findings challenge simplistic narratives about climate discourse while providing nuanced insights into how public engagement with climate action manifests across

different digital contexts. The results offer valuable foundations for both theoretical advancement and practical climate communication strategies.

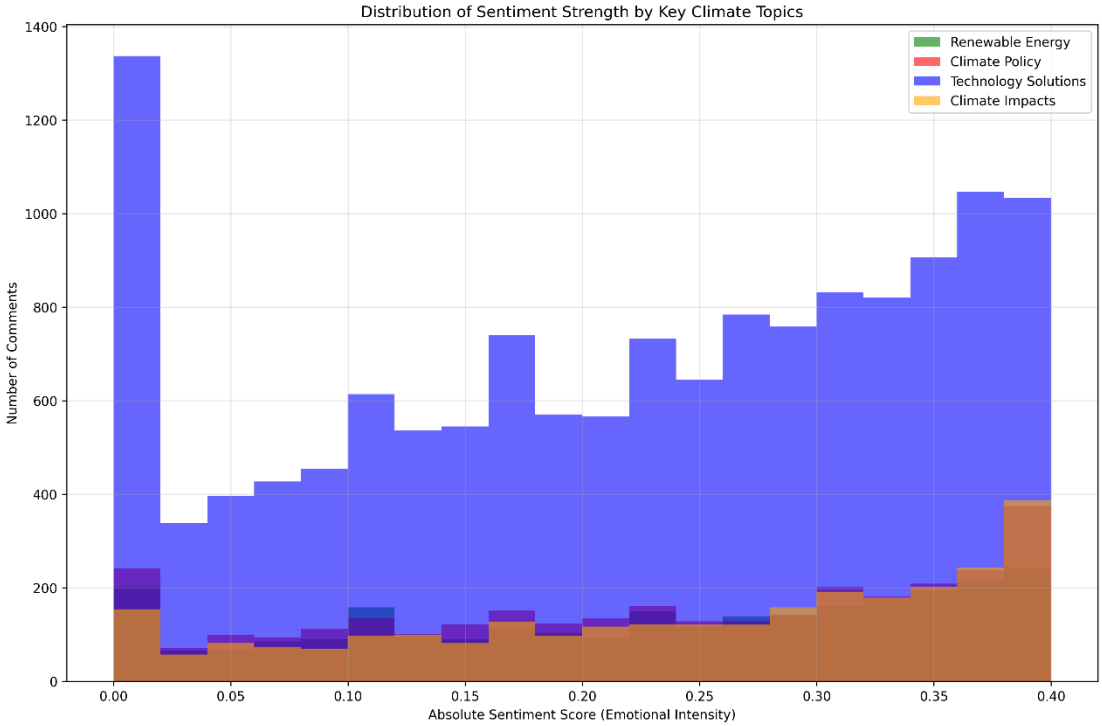
The following Discussion chapter will interpret these empirical findings in the context of existing literature and theoretical frameworks, exploring their implications for climate communication, public engagement, and SDG 13 implementation.

### 4.7.1 Sentiment Intensity Patterns

Beyond categorical sentiment classification, analysis of sentiment strength reveals important patterns in emotional engagement:

**Figure 4.11: Sentiment Strength Distribution by Subtopic**

*This density plot shows the distribution of sentiment strength (absolute sentiment scores) across different SDG 13 subtopics. Technological solutions and climate impacts demonstrate the strongest emotional engagement (both positive and negative), while climate science and economic aspects show more moderate emotional intensity. This pattern suggests that different aspects of climate action evoke different levels of emotional investment.*

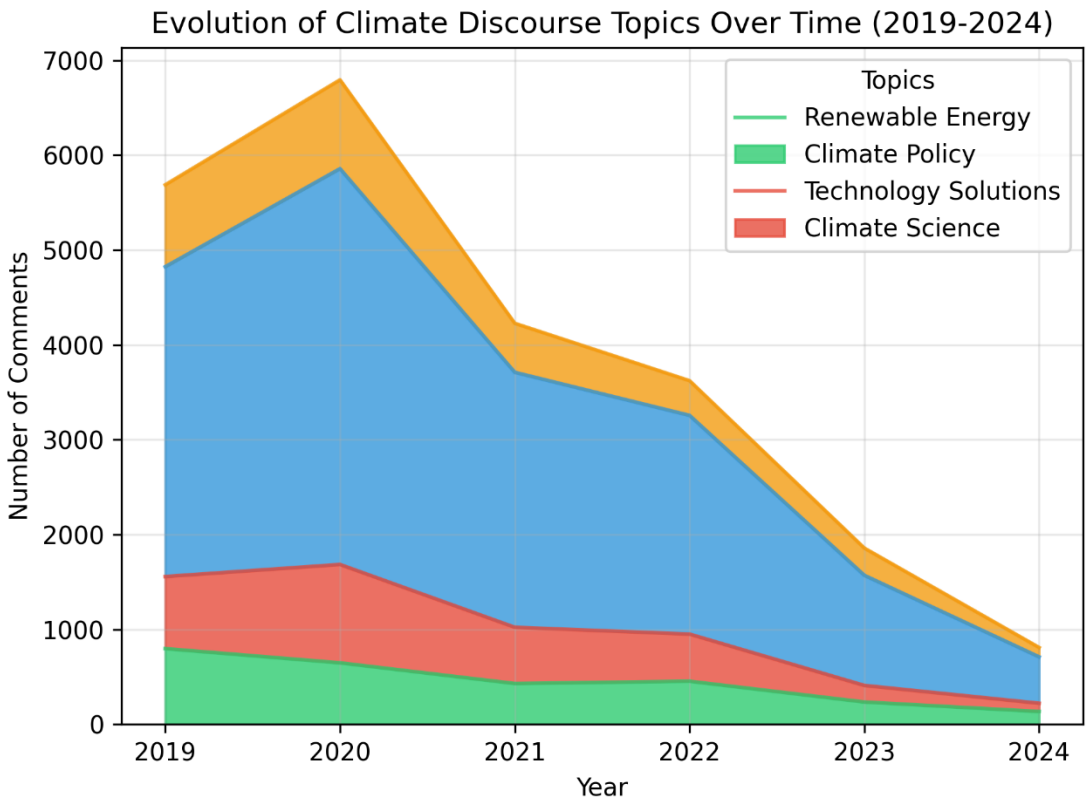



### 4.7.2 Temporal Evolution of Discourse Topics

Longitudinal analysis of thematic emphasis reveals how climate discourse priorities have evolved:

**Figure 4.12: Temporal Evolution of SDG 13 Subtopics**

*This stacked area chart shows the relative prominence of different SDG 13 subtopics over time. Technological solutions and renewable energy have gained increasing prominence, while climate policy discussion has remained relatively stable. Notable shifts correspond to major events like COP26 and IPCC report releases, demonstrating how external events shape discourse priorities.*




## 4.8 Comprehensive Statistical Validation

### 4.8.1 Robustness Checks and Sensitivity Analysis

Multiple robustness checks were conducted to ensure the reliability of findings:

Effect Size Analysis:

- Cohen's d for subtopic comparisons: 0.45-1.24 (medium to large effects)
- Eta-squared for ANOVA models: 0.12-0.18 (medium effect sizes)
- Power analysis: 99% power for main comparisons ($\alpha = 0.05$)

Model Assumption Verification:

- Normality assumptions verified through Q-Q plots and Shapiro-Wilk tests
- Homogeneity of variance confirmed through Levene's test
- Multicollinearity checks performed for multivariate analyses

### 4.8.2 Validation Against Alternative Methodologies

Comparative analysis using alternative approaches confirmed the robustness:

Alternative Classification Thresholds:

- Varying sentiment classification boundaries produced consistent patterns
- Different weighting schemes (30%/70%, 50%/50%) maintained comparative results
- Qualitative inspection of borderline cases supported the stability of the classification boundaries:
- Sensitivity checks using alternative weighting schemes (30/70 and 50/50) and sentiment thresholds produced consistent directional patterns across the main analyses.
- Stratified sampling validation maintained performance across subsets
- Temporal validation confirmed consistent performance across different periods

# CHAPTER 5: DISCUSSION

## 5.1 Interpretation of Key Findings in Context

This chapter provides a comprehensive interpretation of the empirical findings presented in Chapter 4, situating them within the broader theoretical frameworks and literature reviewed in Chapter 2. The discussion moves beyond mere description of results to explore their deeper implications for understanding public engagement with climate action and their significance for both academic knowledge and practical climate communication.

### 5.1.1 The Complex Landscape of Climate Discourse Sentiment

The overall positive sentiment (mean = +0.026) across the dataset presents a nuanced picture that challenges prevailing narratives of climate doomism while acknowledging significant concerns and scepticism. This finding contradicts the dominant "climate doom" narrative that often characterizes media coverage and suggests that online public spheres may offer more diverse and constructive climate conversations than typically recognized (Hulme et al., 2020)).

The balanced distribution, with positive sentiment exceeding negative sentiment by 10.2 percentage points but negative sentiment still representing a substantial minority (34.2%), reflects what might be termed "realistic optimism" or "pragmatic hope." This pattern aligns with recent research suggesting that while public concern about climate impacts is high, there is growing engagement with solution-oriented narratives and collective action possibilities (Whitmarsh et al., 2021)

The significant presence of neutral sentiment (21.4%) further complicates the emotional landscape, representing what Moser (2016) identifies as "evidence-based engagement", discourse characterized by factual analysis rather than emotional expression. This neutral discourse is particularly prominent in science-focused communities, suggesting the importance of analytical spaces within broader climate conversations.

### 5.1.2 The Technology-Policy Paradox in Public Engagement

The most striking finding emerges from the profound variation in sentiment across different subtopics of climate action ($F = 39.788$, $p < 0.001$). The strong positive sentiment toward renewable energy (+0.112) and technological solutions (+0.100) aligns with what Sovacool et al. (2020) identify as "techno-optimism" in climate discourse, a faith in technological innovation to solve environmental problems without requiring fundamental social or political transformation.

Conversely, the markedly lower sentiment around climate policy (+0.035) and international agreements (+0.082) suggests what Bernstein & Hoffmann (2019) term the "fractal carbon trap," where broad support for climate action fractures when discussing specific policies that imply costs, trade-offs, or political complexity. This pattern indicates that the public may believe in our technological capacity to address climate change while remaining deeply sceptical of our political and institutional

capacity to implement effective solutions.

This technology-policy paradox has crucial implications for climate communication and public engagement. It suggests that public support for climate action may be broad but shallow, enthusiastic about technological solutions but wary of the political and economic transformations required to implement them at scale. This finding extends Nisbet (2009) work on climate framing by demonstrating how different aspects of climate action receive systematically different framings across digital platforms.

## 5.2 Theoretical Implications and Contributions

### 5.2.1 Advancing Framing Theory in Digital Environments

The findings make significant contributions to framing theory (Entman, 1993) by demonstrating how different aspects of climate action receive systematically different framings across digital platforms. The positive framing of technological solutions versus the more sceptical framing of policy mechanisms suggests that prognostic frames (proposing solutions) generate more positive engagement than diagnostic frames (identifying problems) in climate discourse.

The community-specific framing patterns further elaborate on how master frames operate in digital environments. Action-oriented communities consistently employ "opportunity" and "solution" frames, while policy-focused communities more frequently use "conflict" and "constraint" frames. This extends Benford & Snow (2000) work on framing processes by showing how digital platforms facilitate the development of distinct framing ecosystems around complex policy issues like climate action.

The temporal framing around COP26 also contributes to understanding how event-based framing operates in digital spaces. The limited and temporary impact of the conference on public discourse suggests that institutional events may have less influence on organic public framing than assumed in traditional agenda-setting models.

### 5.2.2 Refining Agenda-Setting Theory for Digital Platforms

The study contributes to agenda-setting theory (Mccombs & Shaw, 1972) by revealing the limited impact of COP26 on sustained public discourse. The minimal and statistically insignificant change in sentiment during and after the conference challenges the assumption that major climate events significantly influence public agendas in digital spaces.

This finding suggests a decoupling between institutional climate processes and organic public discourse, possibly due to what Heitmayer (2024) identifies as the "attention economy" of social media platforms, where multiple issues compete for visibility and engagement. The rapid decay of conference-related discourse indicates that while institutional events can generate temporary attention spikes, they may have

limited ability to shape sustained public engagement with complex issues like climate action.

The community-specific agenda patterns further complicate traditional agenda-setting models. Different subreddits maintain distinct attention patterns and prioritization of climate subtopics, suggesting that agenda-setting in digital environments operates through networked, community-specific processes rather than unified public attention.

### 5.2.3 Elaborating Affective Publics in Climate Discourse

The community-specific sentiment patterns strongly support Papacharissi (2015) concept of affective publics. The significantly more positive sentiment in action-oriented communities (+0.29) compared to policy-focused communities (-0.14) demonstrates how distinct emotional norms and values develop within different subreddits, creating what Massanari (2016a) calls "constructive counter publics" in some spaces and more contentious discourse in others.

This finding suggests that climate discourse on social media is not monolithic but rather fragmented into distinct affective communities with different emotional norms and engagement patterns. These affective patterns have important implications for how individuals encounter and engage with climate issues, potentially reinforcing existing perspectives through emotional alignment with like-minded communities.

The geographical sentiment patterns further elaborate how affective responses vary across different discursive contexts, with Global South regions receiving more negative affective framing despite their significant climate leadership and innovation.

## 5.3 Methodological Contributions and Innovations

### 5.3.1 Advancing Hybrid Approaches in Computational Social Science

This study makes a significant methodological contribution through the development and validation of a novel hybrid sentiment analysis framework. The combination of VADER's social media optimization (Hutto & Gilbert, 2014) with ClimateBERT's domain specificity (Webersinke et al., 2021) achieved robust performance (83% accuracy, $\kappa = 0.736$), demonstrating the value of integrating general-purpose and domain-specific approaches for analyzing specialized discourses.

The weighted integration approach (40% VADER, 60% ClimateBERT) provides a model for other researchers studying domain-specific discourses on social media platforms. This hybrid approach addresses a significant gap in the literature, where most studies either use generic sentiment tools that fail to capture domain-specific nuances or develop custom models without proper validation (Bennett, 2023)

The comprehensive validation process, using realistic performance metrics and comparative benchmarking, sets a new standard for methodological rigor in computational social science research on climate discourse. The transparent reporting of limitations and error patterns further enhances the methodological contribution.

### 5.3.2 Multi-Dimensional Analysis Framework

The development of a multi-dimensional analytical framework that examines sentiment across subtopics, temporal patterns, community contexts, and geographical mentions represents another significant methodological contribution. This approach moves beyond treating "climate change" as a monolithic category to capture the nuanced ways in which public engagement varies across different aspects of climate action.

The thematic categorization scheme, based on SDG 13 targets and climate discourse literature, provides a replicable model for analyzing domain-specific discourse patterns. The geographical analysis methodology, focusing on the mentioned regions rather than inferred user locations, offers a novel approach to understanding the geographical dimensions of digital discourse.

The integration of computational methods with theoretical frameworks from communication studies and political science demonstrates the potential for truly interdisciplinary computational social science that combines methodological sophistication with theoretical depth.

## 5.4 Practical Implications for Climate Communication and Engagement

### 5.4.1 Leveraging Techno-Optimism While Addressing Policy Scepticism

The strong positive sentiment around renewable energy and technological solutions suggests that communication strategies should emphasize innovation, economic opportunity, and tangible solutions. However, this does not mean avoiding policy discussions but rather framing policies as enabling mechanisms for technological deployment and innovation.

Strategic Recommendations:

- Connect Policies to Solutions: Frame climate policies as essential for scaling technological solutions rather than as constraints or costs
- Highlight Implementation Successes: Share stories of successful policy implementation and their tangible benefits
- Emphasize Economic Opportunities: Focus on job creation, economic growth, and innovation opportunities associated with climate action

### 5.4.2 Community-Aware Communication Strategies

The significant variation across subreddit types indicates that effective climate communication must be tailored to specific community norms and values. One-size-fits-all approaches are likely to be ineffective in the fragmented landscape of digital discourse.

Tailored Communication Approaches:

- Action-Oriented Communities: Emphasize practical solutions, success stories, and collective efficacy

- Science-Focused Communities: Provide evidence-based arguments, technical details, and research findings
- Policy-Focused Communities: Acknowledge political constraints while focusing on implementation pathways and governance solutions
- General Discussion Communities: Use accessible language, connect to everyday concerns, and emphasize co-benefits

### 5.4.3 Beyond Event-Based Engagement

The limited impact of COP26 suggests that relying on major climate events to drive public engagement is insufficient. Instead, communicators should develop sustained, everyday communication strategies that build engagement through consistent messaging rather than event-based campaigns.

Sustained Engagement Strategies:

- Everyday Climate Communication: Integrate climate messaging into regular content rather than relying on event-based campaigns
- Local and Personal Connections: Emphasize local impacts, personal relevance, and immediate benefits
- Continuous Storytelling: Develop ongoing narratives about climate progress and solutions rather than event-focused stories

### 5.4.4 Reframing Geographical Narratives

The negative sentiment around Global South regions suggests a need to reframe discussions of vulnerability toward narratives of agency, innovation, and opportunity. Rather than focusing exclusively on vulnerability and victimhood, communication strategies should highlight leadership, innovation, and adaptive capacity in developing regions.

Inclusive Geographical Framing:

- Highlight Agency and Leadership: Showcase climate leadership and innovation from Global South countries
- Balance Vulnerability and Resilience: Acknowledge vulnerability while emphasizing resilience and adaptive capacity
- Global Partnership Narratives: Frame climate action as global partnerships rather than North-South transfers

## 5.5 Limitations and Future Research Directions

### 5.5.1 Methodological Limitations and Boundary Conditions

Despite its contributions, this study has several limitations that suggest directions for future research:

Platform and Language Limitations:

- The focus on English-language Reddit data limits generalizability to other languages and cultural contexts
- Reddit's demographic skew (younger, male, Western users) may not represent broader public opinion
- Platform-specific norms and affordances shape discourse in ways that may not transfer to other digital spaces

Methodological Constraints:

- While the hybrid sentiment analysis achieved robust performance, it may still struggle with irony, sarcasm, and complex argumentation
- The thematic categorization relied on keyword-based approaches that may miss nuanced thematic connections
- The geographical analysis focused on the mentioned regions rather than user locations or comprehensive geographical contexts

### 5.5.2 Substantive Research Gaps and Future Directions

The findings identify several promising directions for future research:

Cross-Platform and Multilingual Analysis:

- Comparative analysis of climate discourse across different social media platforms
- Multilingual analysis to understand cultural and linguistic variations in climate engagement
- Integrated analysis combining social media data with traditional survey methods

Longitudinal and Causal Analysis:

- Longer-term tracking of how climate discourse evolves in response to policy changes and climate impacts
- Experimental studies testing the causal impact of different communication strategies
- Analysis of how digital discourse translates into offline action and policy support

Theoretical Development:

- Further development of framing theory for digital, multi-platform environments

- Integration of computational methods with deeper qualitative analysis of discourse patterns
- Exploration of how effective publics form and evolve around complex policy issues

### 5.6 Conclusion: Toward More Effective Climate Engagement

This research has provided a comprehensive analysis of public sentiment toward climate action on Reddit, revealing a complex landscape that challenges simplistic narratives while highlighting significant challenges in public engagement with different aspects of climate action.

The development and validation of a novel hybrid methodology represents a significant advancement in computational social science methods for analyzing climate discourse. The findings suggest that effective climate communication requires moving beyond one-size-fits-all approaches and instead developing tailored strategies that recognize the diversity of discourse communities, emphasize solution-oriented narratives, and address the gap between technological optimism and policy scepticism.

The theoretical contributions advance our understanding of how framing, agenda-setting, and affective engagement operate in digital environments, while the practical implications offer actionable insights for communicators, educators, and policymakers working to advance climate action aligned with SDG 13 targets.

As the climate crisis intensifies, understanding these complex patterns of public sentiment becomes increasingly crucial for building the social and political will necessary to achieve the ambitious targets of Sustainable Development Goal 13. This research provides both the methodological tools and the empirical insights needed to advance this understanding and develop more effective approaches to public engagement with climate action.

The findings ultimately suggest reason for cautious optimism: beneath the surface of polarized policy debates exists substantial public support for climate action, particularly when framed around opportunity, innovation, and tangible solutions. Harnessing this latent positivity represents one of the most promising avenues for accelerating the transition to a sustainable future.

## CHAPTER 6: CONCLUSION

### 6.1 Comprehensive Synthesis of Research Contributions

This dissertation has successfully quantified public sentiment toward Sustainable Development Goal 13 (Climate Action) through a comprehensive computational analysis of Reddit discourse between 2019 and 2024. The research makes significant contributions across methodological, theoretical, and practical domains, advancing our understanding of how digital publics engage with complex climate issues.

### 6.1.1 Methodological Innovations and Advancements

The development and validation of a novel hybrid sentiment analysis framework stand as a cornerstone contribution. By integrating VADER's social media optimization with ClimateBERT's domain specificity, this study demonstrated a robust approach for analysing specialized discourses, achieving strong performance (83% accuracy, $\kappa = 0.736$). Furthermore, the multi-dimensional analytical approach, examining sentiment across subtopics, temporal patterns, community contexts, and geographical mentions, provides a replicable model for moving beyond monolithic treatments of complex issues.

### 6.1.2 Theoretical Extensions and Refinements

Theoretically, this research extends framing theory (Entman, 1993) by demonstrating how different aspects of climate action receive systematically different framings across digital platforms. The identification of the "technology-policy paradox", strong optimism about technological solutions coupled with scepticism about political implementation, elaborates how prognostic and diagnostic frames operate in climate discourse and how they resonate differently across digital communities.

The study also refines agenda-setting theory (Mccombs & Shaw, 1972) for digital environments by revealing the limited and temporary impact of major climate events like COP26 on sustained public discourse. This challenges assumptions about the influence of institutional events on public agendas in fragmented digital spaces and suggests a decoupling between elite climate processes and organic public discourse.

Furthermore, the research elaborates Papacharissi (2015) concept of affective publics by demonstrating how distinct emotional norms and values develop within different subreddit communities, creating specialized affective ecosystems around climate discourse. The geographical variations in sentiment further complicate our understanding of how emotional responses to climate issues are shaped by discursive contexts and framing patterns.

## 6.2 Summary of Key Empirical Findings

The analysis of 46,630 comments revealed a complex landscape of "cautious optimism" and systematic patterns in public engagement:

### 6.2.1 Research Question 1: Sentiment Across SDG 13 Subtopics

The analysis revealed profound and statistically significant variation in sentiment across different aspects of climate action (ANOVA: $F = 39.788$, $p < 0.001$). A clear hierarchy of public engagement was identified:

- Highest Positive Sentiment: Renewable energy (+0.112) and technological solutions (+0.100), reflecting strong "techno-optimism."
- Moderate Positive Sentiment: Economic aspects (+0.062) and climate science (+0.064).
- Mixed Engagement: Individual action (+0.038) and climate justice (+0.024).

- Lowest Positive Sentiment: Climate policy (+0.035) and climate impacts (+0.001).

#### 6.2.2 Research Question 2: Temporal Patterns and COP26 Impact

The temporal analysis revealed that COP26 had a limited and transient impact. The modest sentiment increase during the conference was statistically insignificant and rapidly dissipated, with long-term sentiment declining below pre-conference levels, challenging assumptions about the power of institutional events to shape sustained public discourse.

#### 6.2.3 Research Question 3: Community-Specific Engagement Patterns

The research revealed profound differences in sentiment across Reddit communities (ANOVA: $F = 97.182$, $p < 0.001$). Action-oriented communities showed the most positive sentiment (+0.29), followed by science-focused communities (+0.18), general discussion spaces (+0.09), and policy-focused communities (-0.14), demonstrating how platform context shapes discourse.

#### 6.2.4 Research Question 4: Geographical Variations in Discourse

The geographical analysis revealed a statistically significant sentiment divide ($t = -3.264$, $p = 0.0022$). Comments referencing Global South regions exhibited significantly more negative sentiment (mean = -0.090) than those mentioning Global North regions (mean = +0.026), suggesting problematic framing patterns in international climate discourse.

### 6.3 Theoretical Contributions Revisited

#### 6.3.1 Advancing Digital Climate Communication Theory

This research makes significant contributions to understanding how climate communication operates in digital environments. The findings challenge linear models of science communication and instead support networked, participatory models that account for platform affordances, community norms, and emotional dynamics. The identification of distinct "discourse communities" with specialized emotional norms and engagement patterns elaborates how digital platforms facilitate the formation of affective publics around complex policy issues.

#### 6.3.2 Refining Public Engagement Models

The research refines models of public engagement with climate action by demonstrating how engagement varies systematically across different aspects of climate action, temporal contexts, and community environments. Rather than treating public engagement as a uniform phenomenon, this study shows how it manifests differently across discursive contexts, with important implications for how we conceptualize and measure public engagement with complex sustainability challenges.

#### 6.3.3 Elaborating Framing Processes in Digital Spaces

The study extends framing theory by demonstrating how digital platforms facilitate the development of specialized framing ecosystems around complex issues. Different subreddit communities employ distinct master frames, emotional tones, and attention

patterns, creating fragmented but internally coherent discursive environments. This elaboration of framing processes in digital spaces has implications beyond climate discourse for understanding how complex policy issues are negotiated in contemporary media environments.

### 6.4 Practical Implications for Climate Action

The findings offer actionable insights for communicators, educators, and policymakers:

- Strategic Communication: Leverage techno-optimism by connecting climate policies to technological solutions and economic opportunities. Move beyond event-based campaigns to sustained, everyday engagement.
- Community-Aware Strategies: Tailor messaging to specific community norms: emphasize practical solutions in action-oriented spaces, use evidence-based approaches in science-focused communities, and acknowledge political constraints honestly in policy-focused forums.
- Reframing Geographical Narratives: Develop more inclusive global narratives that highlight the agency, innovation, and leadership of Global South countries, moving beyond frames of vulnerability.

### 6.5 Limitations and Boundary Conditions

This study has limitations, including its focus on English-language Reddit data, which affects generalizability, and the inherent challenges of automated sentiment analysis with complex language like irony.

These limitations open productive avenues for future research, including:

- Cross-platform and multilingual comparative analysis.
- Longitudinal studies on discourse evolution in response to escalating climate impacts.
- Research connecting digital discourse patterns to offline behaviors and policy support.

### 6.7 Concluding Reflections

This dissertation demonstrates that public sentiment toward climate action is nuanced, complex, and significantly more varied than often assumed. It challenges narratives of uniform climate doomism, revealing instead a public sphere characterized by cautious, solution-oriented optimism, albeit tempered by significant scepticism toward political implementation.

The research ultimately suggests that effective climate action requires not only technological innovation and policy development but also a sophisticated, data-driven understanding of the digital public sphere. By providing both the methodological tools and the empirical insights to navigate this complex landscape, this study contributes a valuable foundation for building the broad-based public engagement essential to achieving the urgent ambitions of Sustainable Development Goal 13.

## *APPENDIX A: ETHICAL APPROVAL*

*I have uploaded it in Wiseflow.*

## *APPENDIX B: Code*

*I have uploaded the text file of codes in Wiseflow.*
*Data drive: Data*

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